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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: RSS

A view of Dudhkund Lake at Solududhkund Municipality in Solukhumbu district.

PM expresses resolve to implement federalism

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 7



Prime Minister and Chairman of the National Coordination Council, Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', has reiterated his commitment to be firm in the implementation of federalism.

Addressing the second full meeting of the National Coordination Council (NCC) held on Wednesday at the Office of the Prime Minister and Council of Ministers at Singha Durbar, PM Prachanda said, "Chief Ministers have trusted me in the implementation of federalism; with this trust I will move ahead for the effective implementation of federalism."

The Prime Minister recalled that although the law regarding the council was passed in 2018, he held the first meeting in June last year. "Four years passed without a single meeting. I have taken initiative to implement federalism by holding two meetings in six months," he said.

The first meeting of the National Coordination Council was held on July 1, 2023.

Informing that he was in constant discussions with the Chief Ministers of the provinces to implement federalism, PM Prachanda said, "I feel that this meeting has created momentum. I have hope and trust in all the Chief Ministers. This is my strength in implementing federalism."

He has assigned responsibility to the Deputy Prime Ministers for the Federal Civil Service Act and the adjustment of police in provinces. "Our main task is to formulate federal laws. When the provinces start serving the people, that will be a good answer to the anti-federalism elements," said PM Prachanda.

Speaking at the meeting, Deputy Prime Minister and Defense Minister Purna Bahadur Khadka said that the implementation of federalism is a shared responsibility and urged everyone to work with a collective spirit.

Similarly, DPM and Home Minister Narayan Kaji Shrestha said that the process for police adjustment had progressed and would be completed in a few days.

Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs Minister Dhanraj Gurung informed that the ministry was working on the creation of federal laws and assured that most of the federal laws would be passed in the current parliament session.

The meeting discussed the unbundling and detailing of the responsibilities of various levels of government and maintained that it should be made simple, clear and without duplication of responsibilities.

The meeting also delved into the reasons for not being able to issue the Federal Civil Service Act, which is considered a guideline for the provinces and local levels while the necessary laws, rules and standards for the implementation of the list of common rights according to schedule 7 and 9 of the constitution were discussed.

Although the local government can enact a single rights law, it has been emphasised that the problems that arise when the 753 local levels enact separate laws should be properly discussed and managed.

The practice of tax collection by making laws has started at the local level. From the eighth meeting of the Intergovernmental Fiscal Council, decisions have been made to prioritise development projects and eliminate duplication, maximise the use of resources, eliminate the duplication in taxation and create laws necessary for the implementation of fiscal federalism.

Prime Minister Prachanda has given special priority to reducing the financial dependence on the association at the provincial and local levels. He has directed the provincial and local levels to increase their attention towards the proper utilisation of their resources by exercising the rights mentioned in the constitution. He emphasised on the need to strengthen the provincial and local levels by identifying new sources of revenue.

The meeting of the NCC is organised under the chairmanship of the Prime Minister to ensure coordination and interconnection between the three levels of the government. The council has members including Minister for Finance, Minister for Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs, Minister for Home Affairs, and Minister for Federal Affairs and General Administration of the federal government, Chief Ministers of the Provincial Governments, Leader of the opposition party in the House of Representatives and the federal MPs appointed by him and seven members from the local levels with at least three women representatives appointed by the PM.

Lawmakers draw govt attention over slow pace of development

BY PALLAV BHUSAL
Kathmandu, Feb. 7



Lawmakers expressed their concerns about the sluggish pace of various development projects and the poor capital expenditure in the meeting of the House of Representatives on Wednesday.

They also criticised the government for its poor performance and drew attention to address the challenges facing the country.

Lawmaker Gagan Kumar Thapa from the Nepali Congress voiced strong sentiments against individuals involved in government land grabbing and fraudulent activities through cooperatives.

Thapa's unequivocal stance emphasised that, regardless of their influence, those responsible for such crimes should face severe consequences. His impassioned call for justice resonated with the broader sentiment that accountability should be unwavering, transcending political or economic affiliations.

Thapa went further cautioning against the misuse of power in matters related to citizenship. He asserted that even influential figures associated with the political parties should not be exempted from accountability for crimes linked to citizenship cases.

Thapa also drew attention to the inadequacies in the country's education system. Specifically, he called for a comprehensive discussion on the Higher Education Bill within the parliamentary framework, emphasising the critical role education plays in shaping the nation's future.

Additionally, Thapa highlighted the suboptimal state of infrastructure, citing examples like the Kankai bridge in Jhapa. He underscored the necessity for timely road construction to navigate challenges such as tree cutting and payment issues. His plea for a deeper examination of these obstacles instead of engaging in mutual accusations reflected a call for collaborative problem-solving within the parliamentary forum.

Padam Giri, the CPN-UML chief whip, issued a stern warning citing the growing anomalies in the country. Giri's cautionary message resonated with concerns about public discontent escalating if the government fails to demonstrate sensitivity towards critical issues. He specifically highlighted issues such as the repatriation of Nepali individuals recruited in the Russian army and the release of Bipin Joshi from Hamas' control.

Giri also drew attention to the imperative of generating employment opportunities and expediting various development projects. His concerns included the government's perceived inaction, particularly its failure to retrieve the bodies of those who lost their lives while serving in the Russian army. The impassioned plea for government responsiveness extended to the operationalisation of strategic airports, such as Pokhara and Bhairahawa, where substantial investments have yet to yield results.

The MPs delved into topics ranging from the collapse of cooperatives and the Tharu community's inclusion rights to concerns about national debt and the relevance of provinces in the current political landscape.

MP Janardhan Sharma, Deputy General Secretary of Nepal Communist Party (Maoist Centre), stressed that the legislative process should transcend power dynamics, advocating for unity in law-making. He emphasised that the distinction between ruling and opposition parties during legislation is

» SEE PAGE 6

Nine Nobel laureates to attend Lumbini summit

BY LAXMAN PAUDEL
Bhairahawa, Feb.7

Nine Nobel Peace Prize winners are coming to Lumbini to participate in the 4th Laureates and Leaders Summit.

Lumbini Province government is organising 4th Laureates and Leaders for Children: Development and Peace Summit with an aim to spread the message of peace, harmony and compassion in the children's zone and to draw the world's attention for the development of Lumbini.

To participate in the conference, the nine Nobel Peace Prize winners are coming to Lumbini. Established in 1895 in the name of Swedish scientist Alfred Nobel, the Nobel Peace Prize is considered to be the world's largest prize.

The Nobel Prize is awarded to individuals and organizations who have made significant contributions in the fields of literature, peace, physics, chemistry, physiology and medicine and economics.

Dilli Bahadur, Chief Minister of Lumbini Province, said that the summit would express commitment to ending child violence, child labour, child marriage and trafficking of children bringing them in a single platform at the same time in Lumbini.

The summit will be attended by more than 200 dignitaries from Nepal, including nine Nobel Peace Prize winners, children, peace experts, UN development partners, more than 20 foreign dignitaries and officials from government and non-government sectors.

Prime Minister, former prime ministers, ministers, representatives of children and people and organisations associated with peace will participate in the programme.

Jordan's Prince Ali Bin Al-Hussein, economist Jeffrey Sachs, Stefan Lofven, chairman of Stockholm International Peace Research Institute Board, former Panama First Lady, Lorena Castillo, and Inter-Parliamentary Union Secretary General, Martin Chungong, will also attend the conference.

The main theme of the summit is children and peace and the distinguished people from the same areas will participate in the conference.

» SEE PAGE 6

KMC working to manage 22,000 stray dogs

BY SUSHMA MAHARJAN
Kathmandu, Feb. 7

At least once in life, people walking down the streets in Kathmandu have felt threatened by street dogs. Whether it's a day or night, walking or riding two-wheeler, the fear of being chased or attacked by strays is a constant concern. These dogs pose risks to public safety, especially when they come in a group aggressively. Sometimes, their attacks have caused serious injuries for pedestrians, requiring hospital treatment.

But, did you know that the Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC) is consistently working for the safety and well-being of its denizens along with the welfare of the street dogs?

According to the KMC, there are approximately 22,000 stray dogs inside all 32 wards of the metropolis and it has come up with collaborative approaches to control and manage stray dogs.

Dr. Awadesh Jha, head of the KMC's Agriculture and Animal Husbandry Department, said that the department had launched a neutering and vaccination campaign to control stray dogs.



FILE PHOTO

They aim to sterilise 5,800 street dogs by the end of the Fiscal Year 2023/024. According to Jha, approximately 100 personnel were being mobilsed to make it successful.

Controlling stray dogs is not an easy job. Dogs without owners are difficult to tame and care for. At present, the Agriculture and Animal Husbandry Department has coordinated with nine different organisations to sterilize and vaccinate stray dogs in all the wards of the metropolis. They include Sneha Care, Animal Nepal, Vet 4 Ur Pet, Kathmandu Animal Treatment Centre Nepal and others.

Each organisation has deployed a team consisting of at least one veterinary doctor, two assistants, four catchers, a guard and others to identify, vaccinate and neuter street dogs. After identifying the dogs, they are taken to the vet clinic and hospitals for neutering. After operating, they are kept under observation for a day and released in the area they were picked from.

According to the Agriculture and Animal Husbandry Department, it has sterilized 4,938 and vaccinated 11,308 stay dogs in the past few months. Although the target was to sterilize 5,800 dogs by the end of current fiscal year, Dr. Jha said that it would be achieved by the next month.

In the current fiscal year, the metropolis has allocated a total of Rs. 18 million for the campaign. Following it, the department has been providing money at a rate of Rs. 2,500 for neutering one dog and Rs. 200 for vaccinating a dog.

According to Dr. Jha, though the results of the campaign may not be immediately visible, they would be clearly visible within few years. He said, "We are dedicated to reducing the number of street dogs to minimise risks of accidents, bog bites and rabies."

He said that if Kathmandu denizens were facing problems due to stray dogs, they could reach KMC toll-free number – 1180-16600105511-- for assistance.

Construction of Kathmandu's largest substation completed at Matatirtha

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 7



PHOTO: TRN

Newly constructed Matatirtha substation.

The construction of 220/132 kV substation at Matatirtha in Chandragiri Municipality of Kathmandu has been completed. Nepal Electricity Authority has constructed a 220/132 kV substation at Matatirtha in Chandragiri Municipality of Kathmandu under the Marshyangdi-Kathmandu transmission line project.

The Matatirtha 220/132 kV substation has been constructed to supply electricity to Kathmandu Valley from the hydroelectric projects of Trishuli and Marsyangdi river catchment areas and to strengthen the integrated electricity system in the country. The capacity of the substation is 320 MVA.

The Matatirtha substation has become the biggest substation for electricity supply in Kathmandu Valley, according to the NEA. Managing Director of NEA Kul Man Ghising said that the construction of Matatirtha substation has been completed and all equipment, including power transformers, have been successfully tested.

"The 220 kV Trishuli 3B hub or Markichowk substation should be built to charge and operate the Matatirtha substation at 220 kV. However, it seems that the construction of the Markichowk substation will take some time. The Trishuli 3B hub is being charged by March end this year, after the substation is operational, Matatirtha substation will be charged at 220 kV," he said.

"Infrastructure of 220 kV has been prepared for electricity supply in Kathmandu Valley. After electricity supply from this substation, the power supply of Kathmandu Valley will be more sufficient, reliable and qualitative, the country's integrated electricity system will also be strengthened," said Ghising.

The construction of the Marsyangdi-Kathmandu 220 kV double circuit transmission line has been completed from the Markichowk substation at Aanbukhairni in Tanahun to Kathmandu to bring the power of the Marsyangdi river watershed area to the Kathmandu Valley.

The transmission line had been charged to 132 kV and brought into operation in July 2022. As part of the project, a 220/132 kV substation is under construction at Markichowk.

Tara Prasad Pradhan, deputy managing director of NEA's project management directorate, said that the electricity brought into the Kathmandu Valley from Marsyangdi and Trishuli will be supplied from Matatirtha substation through 132 kV to Syuchatar, Chobhar and other areas and locally.

He said that the electricity from Matatirtha can also be supplied to Hetaunda through a 132 kV transmission line. The Authority is constructing a 132 kV substation in Chobhar. The construction of a 132 kV transmission line from Matatirtha to Chobhar has been completed. He said that the contract agreement for construction of 132 kV underground transmission line from Chobhar to Patan in Lalitpur and 132 kV substation in Patan has been signed.

As the performance of the contractor who was awarded the contract for the construction of Matatirtha and Markichok substation under the Marsyangdi-Kathmandu transmission line project was not satisfactory, the Authority canceled the contract and awarded a new contract in December 2021 to complete the remaining work.

The project has been started with the investment of the government and Authority and concessional loan from Asian Development Bank. The estimated cost of the two substations is around Rs. 2 billion.

SWISS BANK UBS REPORTS PRETAX LOSS

AP
Geneva, Feb. 7

UBS on Tuesday reported a fourth-quarter pretax loss of more than $750 million as the Swiss banking giant continued to integrate its longtime rival Credit Suisse after a government-orchestrated merger.

The Zurich-based lender reported losses before tax of $751 million in the quarter, which included losses of more than a half-billion dollars linked to an investment in SIX Group, which operates Switzerland's main stock market. The net loss in the quarter came in at $278 million.

UBS said it expects to complete the merger of Credit Suisse by the end of the second quarter this year, and the merger of the two banks' Swiss operations by the end of the third quarter.

The company plans to increase its dividend for the 2023 financial year by 27 percent, and said it would resume share buybacks in the second half of the year.

"As we move to the next phase of our journey, we will focus on restructuring and optimizing the combined businesses," CEO Sergio Ermotti said in a statement. "While our progress over the next three years will not be measured in a straight line, our strategy is clear."

The bank said net new assets came in at $22 billion during the fourth quarter, which marked a slowdown from the injection of new assets shortly after the merger was completed in June last year.

Manang hoteliers suffer as tourist arrival decline



PHOTO: YADU PRASAD BHATTA /TRN

Tourists in Manang some months before. The number of visitors has gone down drastically now due to cold.

BY YADU PRASAD BHATTA
Manang, Feb. 7

Hotel businessmen in Manang have been suffering due to the decline in tourist arrivals due to extreme cold. Dozens of hotel businesses operate around the Annapurna foot trail, targeting tourists coming to the Annapurna region. With the reduction in tourists, hotel businesses face problems as their daily income drops, leading to difficulties in sustaining their families.

Dhak Bahadur Bhujel, Chief of the Annapurna Conservation Area Project (ACAP) in Manang, has informed that the number of foreign tourists arriving daily has plummeted from 300 to a mere dozen or even half a dozen.

He stated, "It is not precisely zero, but the influx of tourists has decreased due to the cold. However, it tends to gradually pick up after March. Additionally, tourists are also venturing to Thorang La Pass and Tilicho Lake."

Thuten Lama, Ward Chairman of Nason Rural Municipality-5, who is also a hotelier, said that due to the absence of tourists, he had to shut down his hotel and roam around the neighboring district. He said, "Previously, there was snow, and tourists would visit to witness it. However, now that the snowfall has ceased, tourists mainly come to see Kalapatthar (dark rock). Numerous hotels have shut down. The hotel industry is not thriving enough to sustain everyone's livelihood." Aait Bahadur Gurung, who operates a hotel at the entrance of the Annapurna foot trail, is facing considerable distress. He said that during the peak season, he typically earns Rs. 30,000 to 35,000 daily. However, with very few tourists in the area currently, he is deeply concerned about supporting his family without any income.

Bhupendra Gurung, in-charge of the ACAP Tourist Check and Information Centre in Dharapani, said that the number of tourists is rising as the weather clears up. However, there have been no tourists in the area for up to two weeks.

He informed that 13 foreign tourists entered Manang on Monday, Tuesday, and Wednesday. He said that until summer starts, the number of tourists will decrease, leading to a drop in income for tourism businessmen, possibly reaching zero. More than 35,000 tourism professionals depend on this trail, with the tourism sector being the primary source of income for most of them.

Tourists visit Manang to admire the mountain scenery, experience the local customs of the people, and appreciate the natural beauty of the region.

The Annapurna Trail links five districts -- Lamjung, Manang, Kaski, Mustang, and Myagdi. The entrance to this trail, recognised as one of the top ten foot trails globally, is located in Lamjung's Besisahar. With the trail now deserted, not only are tourism professionals affected, but also hundreds of hotel employees, porters, and tourist guides are facing significant challenges.

Hydro Expo to be held in April

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 7



PHOTO: TRN

IPPAN officials at a press meet.

Aiming to contribute to the government's plans to generate 28,500 MW electricity by 2035, the Himalayan Hydro Expo 2024 is scheduled to be held in April, 2024.

The Independent Power Producers' Association, Nepal (IPPAN) is going to organise the fourth edition of the Himalayan Hydro Expo from April 24 to 26, this year at Bhrikutimandap Exhibition Centre in Kathmandu.

Speaking at a press conference, IPPAN President Ganesh Karki said that the aim of the expo organised by IPPAN is to create an investment environment by inviting foreign investors to participate in the investment expo to be organised by the government in April, 2024.

The IPPAN has been organising the expo every two years aiming to bring in world-class technology in Nepal for the development of hydropower. The expo will contribute to the government's plans to generate 28,500 MW electricity by 2035, he said.

The government has prepared an energy development roadmap with a target of generating 28,500 MW of electricity in 12 years and plans to consume 13,500 MW of electricity internally and export 10,000 MW to India and 5,000 MW to Bangladesh.

"An agreement has been reached between Nepal and India that Nepal will export 10,000 megawatts of electricity to India in 10 years.

In this context, the expo is going to be organised with the aim of attracting domestic and foreign investment in the hydropower sector," he said.

President Karki said that the agreement would create important opportunities in Nepal's energy development and open more doors.

He said that the banks and financial institutions should increase investment in energy, and the government should announce more concessions for energy production.

The government should be more active and move immediately to solve the administrative and procedural problems, he said.

He said, "It is impossible to export as well as generate so much electricity without the involvement of the private sector. The private sector is also ready to achieve the goal of electricity export."

The installation capacity of hydropower operating in the country has reached 2,910 MW, out of it, around 2,214 MW electricity has been produced from the hydropower projects run by the private sector. About 131 hydropower projects having a capacity of 3,397 MW are in the under construction phase.

About 138 hydropower projects with capacity of 3,615 MW are in the stage of financial management and 258 projects with the capacity of 19,623 MW are in the various stages of construction by taking license.

According to IPPAN, there will be an exhibition of machinery tools used in the construction of hydropower projects, banks and financial institutions, insurance companies, cement, rods and other materials in the expo.

Along with this, seminars and discussions on hydropower, solar, hydrogen and other topics will also be organised, said the IPPAN. In the expo, demos will be presented to provide information about various hydropower projects as well as competition between innovative ideas in the energy sector.

The foreign companies and stakeholders from different countries, including China, India, Canada, Norway, South Korea, Germany, Austria, Italy, Sweden, United Kingdom and Brazil will participate in the expo.

It is expected that there will be more than 200 stalls in the expo, whereas 50 per cent stalls will be for foreigners. According to IPPAN, the booking for stalls has been opened from Wednesday itself.

Toyota raises profit after solid earnings

AP
Tokyo, Feb. 7

Toyota raised its full fiscal year profit forecast Tuesday after reporting its profit in the October to December quarter nearly doubled from the year before.

Toyota Motor Corp.'s third quarter profit totaled 1.36 trillion yen ($9 billion), up from 727.9 billion yen in the same period in 2022, as Japan's top automaker recovered from losses suffered when the coronavirus pandemic slammed computer chip production.

In the first nine months of the fiscal year, Toyota reported a 3.9 trillion yen ($26 billion) profit, more than double what it racked up the previous fiscal year.

A favorable exchange rate also helped the maker of the Camry sedan, Prius hybrid and luxury models. A weak yen raises the value of overseas earnings when they are converted into yen. The dollar has been trading at about 148 yen lately, up from 140 yen a year ago.

Quarterly sales rose 23% to 12.04 trillion yen ($81 billion) from 9.75 trillion yen. Toyota, based in central Japan's Toyota city, raised its full fiscal year profit forecast to 4.5 trillion yen ($30 billion), from an earlier forecast of 3.95 trillion yen ($27 billion). It earned 2.45 trillion yen in profit in the year that ended in March 2023.

Toyota also raised its full year sales projection to 43.5 trillion yen ($294 billion), from an earlier estimate of 43 trillion yen ($290 billion). It was 37 trillion yen in the previous fiscal year.

Cost cuts, marketing efforts and the currency exchange effects are behind its revision of its forecast, Toyota said. The company did not raise its vehicle sales forecast for the full fiscal year, instead cutting it to 9.45 million vehicles. Toyota had earlier expected to sell 9.6 million vehicles. Even the lower forecast is better than the previous fiscal year's sales of 8.8 million vehicles.

The shortage of computer chips has hurt automakers, including Toyota. Production has been suspended recently at Toyota group's Daihatsu Motor Co., which makes small models, under Japanese government orders after the automaker admitted it had faked safety tests for decades.

No major accidents have been reported in connection with the cheating, but the tests will have to be carried out properly. The scandal began after a whistleblower came forward in April 2023. Daihatsu has apologized and promised sweeping reforms of its corporate culture.

The impact on Toyota sales and profits will be relatively limited because the subsidiary makes up a small fraction of Toyota's massive global sales and production. But Toyota acknowledged sales for the year will decline in Japan because of Daihatsu's problems. The scandal has been a blow to Toyota's brand image, as similar irregularities have emerged lately at other group companies like Hino and Toyota Industries.

विद्युत उत्पादन कम्पनी लिमिटेड
Vidhyut Utpadan Company Limited

NOTICE FOR THE LETTER OF INTENT TO AWARD THE CONTRACT

(Date of Publication: february 8, 2024)

Pursuant to Sub Sections 27.2 and 27.3 of the Public Procurement Act, 2063, this is to notify all the bidders who submitted their bids for the execution of **Construction of Test Adit Tunnels of Mugu Karnali Storage Hydro Electric Project (MKHEP, 1902MW)** at Piluchaur, Bajura as per the invitation for bids published on October 12, 2023 in "The Rising Nepal" National Daily and www.bolpatra.gov.np that the following listed substantially responsive lowest evaluated bidder has been selected for the award of the contract.

Contract No.	Substantially Responsive Lowest Evaluated Bidder	Evaluated Bid Price
VUCL/MKHEP-TAT/W/NCB/2080-081/01	M/S Pabita- Paradise JV (Lead: Paradise Builders Pvt. Ltd., Sub: Pabita Nirman Sewa) Jwagal, Lalitpur -10, Nepal	NRs. 193,241,330.11 **(including VAT & P.S.)**

CC to:
M/S B.P. Construction Pvt. Ltd., Chhetrapur, Bharatpur-2,Chitwan
M/S Sherpa Hydro Construction Pvt. Ltd , Boudha, Kathmandu
M/S High Himalaya Hydro Construction Pvt. Ltd., Dhobighat, Lalitpur-3
M/S Devkota Nirman Sewa Pvt. Ltd., Kathmandu-15, Swoyambhu
M/S Bavari Construction Pvt. Ltd., Chandol, Dhumbarahi, Kathmandu-4

KARNALI GOVERNMENT FOR INTRA-PROVINCE AIR SERVICE

RSS
Karnali, Feb. 7

The Karnali Province government has begun preparations for internal air transport to connect all the districts of the province. The province government is working with air service operators including the state-owned Nepal Airlines Corporation to operate domestic air flight services from the Surkhet Airport in the provincial capital Birendranagar to the airports in the mountainous districts.

Accordingly, the NAC is collaborating with the provincial government to expand domestic air services from Surkhet. In this regard, Chief Minister Rajkumar Sharma, Coordinator of NAC in Surkhet Mahesh Kumar Marita, Manager of the Engineering Department of NAC Devendra Pun, Chief of Surkhet Civil Aviation Office Rajan Dhungel made an onsite-inspection of the airport on Tuesday.

On the occasion, Chief Minister Sharma said that the government would provide support for physical infrastructure and others required for the domestic flights. The provincial government is adding internal flights to make the life of Karnali residents easier, he said while stating that the provincial government has kept the improvement of Surkhet airport as a priority. Meanwhile, NAC Coordinator Marita said that the service would be operated as soon as possible in consideration of the request made by the provincial government.

Two pregnant women rescued from Kalikot

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Kalikot, Feb. 7

Two pregnant women were rescued by helicopter from Kalikot on a single day. One of the women was rescued from Palanta Rural Municipality-6 and another from Pachaljharana Rural Municipality 9 of Kalikot district.

When she was unable to give birth to her baby in the local health post, Riuli Rokaya of Palanta was airlifted to the Provincial Hospital in Surkhet by helicopter on Wednesday morning as advised by the health workers. Likewise, Ausi Tirua from Pachaljharna was rescued in the evening, according to Assistant Chief District Officer of Kalikot Saroj Adhikari.

Given the urgency of her labour pains, she was timely rescued by helicopter. Local Jayamal Budha praised the helicopter rescue plan for women in remote parts of the country as an excellent initiative of the government. Budha expressed that had there not been the programme, the woman could not have been saved.

Deputy Secretary and Information Officer at the President's Office Archana Khadka said that the Presidential Women's Upliftment Programme, initiated during the tenure of former President Bidya Devi Bhandari, was aimed at serving the women of the remote areas.

She informed many pregnant women and new mothers have been rescued and saved from the remote areas by giving continuity to the programme. The project is operating under the Ministry of Women, Children, and Senior Citizens.

Upon receiving a recommendation from the relevant health institution, the District Administration Office forwards a reference to the Ministry of Home Affairs. In cases where pregnant women in remote areas encounter difficulties during childbirth, immediate helicopter rescue operations are initiated to ensure their safety.

Nita Sharma, the Air Rescue Liaison Person for the Ministry of Women, Children, and Senior Citizens, emphasised that the President's Women's Upliftment Programme has effectively put an end to premature deaths of women. She further highlighted that the programme has been a big relief to women of remote areas and underscored the ministry's commitment to ensuring its long-term sustainability.



PHOTO: PREM RAJ SIMKHADA/TRN

A pregnant woman, Ausi Tiruwa, getting airlifted to the Provincial Hospital in Surkhet from a village in Kalikot district by helicopter. She was unable to give birth to her baby in the local health post.

DAMAULI HOSPITAL MANAGES OXYGEN THROUGH PIPES

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Tanahun, Feb. 7

For the first time, arrangements to provide oxygen to patients' beds through a pipe system have been made in Damauli Hospital located in the district headquarters of Tanahun.

The hospital has facilitated the direct supply of oxygen through pipes, invented by the hospital, to various wards such as emergency, dialysis, indoor, outdoor and pressure application rooms.

According to the hospital, the pipe arrangements were constructed during the COVID-19 period.

Superintendent of the hospital Dr. Pariwartan Baral said that after introducing the pipe system, there was no need to carry oxygen cylinders to the patients' beds. He said that the pipeline was constructed with technical expertise and was brought into operation without additional cost since it was already constructed during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Meanwhile, the number of patients suffering from fever, pneumonia and other cold-related illnesses has increased in the hospital. According to Dr. Baral, approximately 350 patients visit the hospital for the treatment of cold-related diseases every day.

He said, "There is a significant increase in the number of patients suffering from cold-related illnesses, especially children and elderly. The hospital has remained busy lately. Usually, around 200 patients used to visit the hospital but at present around 350 patients visit the hospital daily."

I will work without prejudice: DIG Khapung



BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Taplejung, Feb. 7

Newly transferred Chief of the Koshi Province Police Office, Deputy Inspector General (DIG) Chandra Kuber Khapung has said that he is committed to shouldering the responsibility remaining within the jurisdiction of the province police.

DIG Khapung, who came to Taplejung for the first time after becoming the Koshi Province Police Chief on Tuesday, said this during a meeting with local journalists.

He said that he would carry out his responsibilities within the jurisdiction of the province and federal police structure adhering to the constitutional norms without resorting to any cheap popularity. He said that the powers of the police should be implemented with sincerity. He said that he would carry out the responsibilities without being prejudiced.

DIG Khapung said that no compromise would be made in the work of providing peace and security as people have great trust and expectations from the police.

He also instructed the police personnel under the province to commit to work according to the assigned rights and responsibilities.

In a different context, Deputy Inspector General Khapung said that the differences regarding the cable car project proposed to be built in Pathibhara should be resolved through mutual coordination. He said that the police organisation was in favour of managing the cable car project without any differences.

He also said that there was no immediate possibility of the management requiring the vacancy of Nepal Police personnel to the province police office.

DIG Khapung said that since the issue of police adjustment was being raised at the provincial level and federal level, he expressed his belief that the issue of police adjustment and required manpower would only be addressed through the Provincial Police Act and the relevant provincial government.

Bhaktapur Municipality decides to rebuild Thanthu Durbar

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 7

Bhaktapur Municipality has decided to proceed with the process for the reconstruction of Thanthu Durbar located at Ward No. 3 of Bhaktapur Municipality.

A meeting of the Municipality held on Monday under the chairmanship of Bhaktapur Municipality Mayor Sunil Prajapati decided to proceed with the process of the reconstruction work according to the revised map of Thanthu Durbar.

Mayor Prajapati said that the stakeholders had already agreed to reconstruct the Thanthu Palace in the old original style by adding soil.

The reconstruction process of the palace will be carried out as per the revised map submitted by the Thanthu Durbar Building Reconstruction Technical Committee, he said.

A team consisting of Director General of the Department of Archaeology (DoA) Saubhagya Pradhanang, Chief Archaeological Officer of DoA, Ram Bahadur Kunwar, senior archaeologist Kosh Acharya and Prof. Dr. Robin Cunningham of Durham University and Chief of National Art Museum, Aruna Nakarmi, had inspected the Thanthu Palace reconstruction site on December 28, 2023.

Mayor Prajapati said that the reconstruction process of the palace would move ahead in coordination with the Department of Archeology.

Rajani Joshi, Deputy Mayor of Bhaktapur Municipality, said that the reconstruction of Thanthu Durbar was moving ahead as a pride project of Bhaktapur Municipality.

Aruna Nakarmi, chief of the Memorial Conservation and Palace Maintenance Centre, Bhaktapur, said the revised map of Thanthu Durbar was appropriate from the archaeological point of view.

Historian Purushottam Lochan Shrestha said that the 55-window palace of Bhaktapur Durbar Square Area has been seen as part of Thanthu Durbar.

The structural design of the palace reconstruction work has almost been completed, said Sunil Duwal, Professor of Khwopa Engineering College.

The soil quality, identification of soil source and sample testing of soil for reconstruction have been carried out, he said.



PHOTO: TRN

Thanthu Durbar located at Bhaktapur Municipality.

FNJ calls for media-friendly bill

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 7

The Federation of Nepali Journalists (FNJ) has urged the government to move ahead with the formulation of media-related bills based on the Constitution of Nepal, the universal standards and practice of freedom of press and expression.

A meeting of the FNJ officers and members on Wednesday decided to welcome the government's initiative to present the media bill in the current session of the parliament.

The bill should go through the parliamentary process after extensive discussion and consultation with the concerned parties including the FNJ.

Considering the current situation where the media sector is facing a financial crisis, the FNJ has appealed to the government to adopt a policy of protecting the media sector, by among others, creating a media-friendly environment and increasing public welfare advertisements while distributing it proportionately.

The FNJ has also demanded that the new media be classified and included as eligible for getting public welfare advertisements.

Month-long 'Ex-Balance Nail' exercise between Nepali and US Army begins

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 7

The 41st edition of the joint training exercise between the Nepali Army and the US Army called 'Ex-Balance Nail,' has begun from Tuesday in Kathmandu. The joint training of such a model has been operating between the two nations since 2004.

A total of 46 security forces including 36 soldiers from the Nepali Army and 10 from the American Army are participating in the joint training exercise, according to the Directorate of Public Relations and Information of the Army Headquarters.

The training exercise will be conducted in the cantonment and Nagarkot area till March 7, focusing on disaster management, search and rescue and humanitarian aid among others, according to Directorate and Spokesperson for the Nepali Army Brigadier General Krishna Prasad Bhandari.

The Nepali Army has been participating in joint training and exercises with the military organisations of the United States, UK, India, China, Mongolia, Indonesia and other countries on search and rescue, disaster management, counter-terrorism, mountain climbing and United Nations peacekeeping missions.

At the same time, the fourth edition of 'Multinational Peacekeeping Exercise Shanti Prayas-IV' is being organised with the support of the Global Peace Operation Initiative (GPOI) at Shree Birendra Peacekeeping Operation Training Centre from February 20 to 24.



PHOTO: AP

Soldiers of the Nepali Army and the American Army in joint training exercise in Kathmandu.

Dhaubadi Iron Company Limited
(an undertaking of Government of Nepal)
Lainchaur, Kathmandu

Request for Expression of Interest to be registered in a Roster list for Mining Scheme

First Publication Date: **8th February, 2024 (25/10/2080 B.S)**

Dhaubadi Iron Company Limited (DICL) is an undertaking government company. The prime objectives of the company are to establish an Iron and steel plant based on Dhaubadi Iron Ore Deposits located in Dhaubadi Area, Hupsekot RM, East Nawalparasi, Gandaki Province, Nepal. In this regard, DICL plans to create a **Roster List** of consulting firms for the *"Preparation of mining scheme for the Dhaubadi-Pokhari iron ore mineralization area, at Hupsekot rural municipality, East Nawalparasi, Gandaki province, Nepal"*. DICL invites eligible and qualified consulting firms to indicate their interest in being listed in a roster for providing consultancy service proposals along with the following documents:

- Company's registration certificate/VAT/PAN and Updated Tax Clearance Certificate.
- Company's available technical manpower and their expertise and experience.
- Company's Profile (Experience and Capabilities) in the field of metal/non-metal exploration, mine plan, and design.
- At least 7 years of Work experience in preparation of Mining Schemes and Mining projects.
- List of manpower (Mining Engineer, Geologist, Environmentalist, Surveyor, Finance Expert), experience, and Academic qualification preferably master.
- The average last 3 years' minimum turnover shall be NRs. 0.30 million.

The experienced consulting firms with the above-required documents can apply with necessary documents at **info@dicl.org.np** or company address Lainchour, Kathmandu (Premises of Department of Mines and Geology) before **12.00 23rd February, 2024 (11/11/2080 B.S.)**

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Expect problems and eat them for breakfast.
- Alfred A. Montapert

EDITORIAL

Foreign Reserves Rise

Against all odds, Nepal's economy is showing signs of gradual recovery. A report on the current macroeconomic and financial status, published by the Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB) Tuesday, reveals that the external sector of the economy has improved significantly during the first six months of the current fiscal year 2023/24. Foreign currency reserves, balance of payments, current account and remittance inflows have picked up. This amply shows that measures taken to boost the slackening post-pandemic economy was pragmatic and satisfactory, busting all the rumours that the economy was heading to imminent collapse like that of Sri Lanka. The NRB's data also reflects resilience of Nepali economy in the face of internal and external shocks. Last September, Asian Development Bank (ADB) predicted that Nepal's economy was expected to grow by 4.3 per cent (at market prices) in the fiscal year 2024, up from an estimated growth of 1.9 per cent in FY 2023. This projection is based on flexible monetary policy, moderation in inflation and comfortable foreign reserves.

The NRB's latest macroeconomic report also corroborates the ADB's estimate of economic growth. The gross foreign exchange reserves increased by 18 per cent to Rs. 1816.57 billion in mid-January 2024 from Rs. 1539.36 billion in mid-July 2023. This is indeed remarkable achievement as the country had witnessed sharp decline in the foreign reserves due to the constant fall in the inflow of remittances caused by prolonged impact of pandemic in 2021 and 2022. For the least developed countries like Nepal, the foreign reserves play a vital role in ensuring access to global market. They help in maintaining balance of trade and balance of payments (BoP) while stabilising exchange rate, attracting foreign investment, mitigating financial crisis and spurring economic growth.

The country saw the remittance inflow increase by 25.3 per cent to Rs. 733.22 billion in the review period compared to an increase of 24.3 per cent in the same period of the previous year. The remittance of Rs. 120 billion was received in a single month from mid-December 2023 to mid-January 2024 of the current fiscal year. The number of Nepali workers, both institutional and individual, taking first-time approval for foreign employment was 207,970 and taking approval for renew entry was 135,435. Though reliance on the remittance is not good for the country in the long run, it has enabled to reduce the rate of poverty in rural areas. Prudent policy needs to be adopted to divert the remittance in the productive sectors so that gainful jobs are created at home and exodus of youths going abroad will be checked.

The current account remained at a surplus of Rs. 161.62 billion in the review period against a deficit of Rs. 35.57 billion in the same period of the previous year. Similarly, balance of payment remained at a surplus of Rs. 273.52 billion in the review period against a surplus of Rs. 92.15 billion in the same period of the previous year. Capital transfer declined by 30 per cent to Rs. 3.11 billion and net foreign direct investment (FDI) remained positive at Rs. 4.53 billion. Likewise, the y-o-y consumer price inflation moderated to 5.26 per cent in mid-January 2024 compared to 7.26 per cent a year ago. These positive indicators are also encouraging at a time when biting recession is still lingering, with many retailors shutting down their businesses and shifting to other professions or leaving the country.

Embrace Thrift Culture

BRITTI ARYAL

In recent years, the practice of shopping for second-hand items has become a lot more popular in Nepal. The increasing trend of thrifting for cheaper and more fashionable goods has become the best way for sustainability. It is no longer associated with poverty. The rising popularity of thrifting among more wealthy consumers has made it easier for low-income communities to follow the trend as well. Purchasing items that are preused or discarded has shown a good way to sustain economically.

A contemporary concept of purchasing a product at a discounted price hasn't just reduced the demand for new products at high costs but has also reduced the energy required to produce, package, and transport the items. From saving money to reducing waste and promoting sustainability, thrifting has offered many benefits. The growing culture of upcycling and repurposing old items isn't just about saving money, it's also about saving the planet.

Most of the unwanted items we throw often end up where they shouldn't be like in the waste yard or landfills, affecting the environment. Fast fashions and overconsumption have created an environmental crisis. An excessive amount of carbon emission from such type of pollution can lead to climate change, increasing different types of health issues, and thrifting has helped reduce such environmental abuse. It has prodded people to fully utilise resources and save the environment by decreasing their carbon footprints.

In the world of throwaways, embracing thrift has been a revolutionary act. The value we place on an item we buy is often a reflection of their prices, and the rise of thrifting has contributed to developing a culture of producing goods in needed amount. Thrifting not only helps to contribute to the local communities by creating jobs and supporting the local economy but also teaches ethical shopping by supporting a good cause for charity or community service.

The culture of thrifting has worked to lessen the overproduction of goods instead of increasing production and turning it into waste. Buying an item from a thrift store is not only beneficial for a buyer; it is equally advantageous for the sellers of the items that are no longer in use who can make some money by selling them to second-hand markets. This is extremely important to reduce waste.

Through recycling, upcycling, and supporting local communities, thrifting enables us to be more conscious consumers and reduce our environmental impact. From saving money and cultivating a unique style to reducing waste and promoting sustainability, thrifting offers many advantages. It is necessary to create awareness and introduce a thrifting culture among many to bring a change.

Donating and buying second-hand clothing is a simple way for everyone to make a difference and a good chance to make eco-friendly choices that align with our values. So, instead of buying new items, it is better to reuse, recycle, and choose thrifting as far as practicable. Try to make a positive difference for yourself and the planet.

Jimmy Carter: Architect Of Peace



Mukti Rijal

This writer was one of the participants at a training workshop on facilitative mediation organised by an agency in Nepal a few years ago. It was designed and led by two US mediation training experts Edward Miller and Therese Miller who had run several training courses of similar import in Sri Lanka and many other parts of the world. The training workshop was crafted into several modules placing larger focus and share of practical exercises, including buzz group discussions, role plays, mock drills, case studies and many other experiential learning methods.

In one of the sessions during the training, a group discussion was held in which training facilitators shared with participants a big list of foundational qualities of an effective mediator and invited all in the room to name the persons who they think – be in their families, neighbourhoods, district, country or at the global level – would meet the requirements and have worked as the effective dispute resolvers and peacemakers in their respective contexts. Some took the name of one's own parents who made peace among the family members through their grit and grace while others named global figures like BP Koirala, Lord Buddha, Mahatma Gandhi, Nelson Mandela and so on as the examples of good mediators.

Pragmatic idealist

However, when it came to the turn of the training facilitators themselves, Edward Miller named former US president Jimmy Carter who in his opinion was a pragmatic idealist who put his efforts and resources to make peace in the world. Carter is known for his tireless work with Habitat for Humanity, and he won a Nobel Peace Prize in 2002 for his efforts to promote peace and democracy around the world.

Carter is widely known in Nepal too who was effortful to help resolve the ten-year-long armed conflict in Nepal. He had come to Nepal leading the Carter Centre's team to observe the first constituent assembly elections held in 2008 in Nepal. He is known worldwide for his success in negotiating the Camp David Accords between Israel and Egypt signed on 1978. This was the first such treaty agreed between Israel and any of its Arab neighbours brokered by Carter between the then Israeli Prime Minister Minachem Begin and Egyptian President Anwar Sadat.

The accord document was titled the framework for peace in the Middle East and the negotiations to conclude it had taken place at the US president's retreat at Camp David, Maryland. Both Sadat and Begin were awarded the Nobel Prize for peace in 1978 for their contributions to the agreements. The two leaders accepted Carter's invitation, and their summit had lasted for 13 days. Carter, Begin and Sadat were accompanied by their leading foreign policy advisers, but Carter preferred that the three men work together in private sessions in a small office at Aspen, his cabin at Camp David. Carter's genius as a mediator was his belief that there is some innate goodness in every person, no matter the harm they may perpetrate.

> He ultimately put forth a detailed American peace plan, which became a working template that the parties could build upon and, ultimately, provided the framework of the final agreement

At a time when Middle East is stuck into the spiral of intractable conflict engendered due to Hamas-Israel fighting, it would be in order to take cognizance of the Carter's negotiation strengths well documented in programme on negotiation (PON) reports and papers at Harvard Law School. Carter is often assessed as a weak president who failed to tackle the considerable problems facing the United States in the 1970s and early 1980s. Despite this criticism, Carter was a key architect of the Camp David accords who persuaded Sadat and Begin in negotiating their own resolution for peace.

He ultimately put forth a detailed American peace plan, which became a working template that the parties could build upon and, ultimately, provided the framework of the final agreement. In the end, the Camp David Accords succeeded not because the most ideal partners were at the table, but rather because President Carter was available to push them ahead with an abundant amount of political courage.

Carter, for example, holed up at Camp David for two weeks in the face of soaring inflation and gas prices in the United States and an adverse situation in Iran. His bold stance contrasts with the more cautious approach of many politicians in our own era towards international conflict resolution. Switching from the role of facilitator to lead negotiator carries considerable risk for a politician. But when Begin and Sadat refused to engage with each other, Carter put forth the outlines of an agreement. Draft proposals he presented did inspire the Begin and Sadat to discuss intensively to discover underlying interests and deepen their understanding of the issues to reach to an agreement.

Results-oriented

Carter's style was results-oriented rather than process-driven. He brought an engineer's mind to every problem and was ready with possible solutions. He could be stubborn. But he was always willing to make principled decisions, even if they cost him politically. According to reports, when – as president in 1977 – President Carter signed the Panama Canal Treaties to hand over control of the canal to Panama by 1999, he was heavily criticized by many members of the US Congress.

But with the treaties, Carter ended an arrangement that had allowed the U.S. to control the canal and was viewed as colonialism by many Latin American nations. Carter always believed that negotiation was more fruitful than force. As president, he leaned into this philosophy with the Israeli-Egyptian peace accords and did the same thing to help Haiti reestablish democracy as leader of the Carter Center.

(The author is presently associated with Policy Research Institute (PRI) as a senior research fellow. rijalmukti@gmail.com)

Hazard Of Over-the-counter Antibiotics



Dr Pushpa R Joshi

Antibiotics, once hailed as miraculous lifesavers, are now confronted with an escalating threat in Nepal, primarily due to a lack of awareness and a weak drug regulatory framework. The pervasive issues of self-medication, inadequate prescription practices, and the uncontrolled use of antibiotics in livestock and agriculture have collectively exacerbated the problem. According to a preliminary report from the study analsing the effect of community education and surveillance of antibiotics use among young children in Nepal, a staggering 65 per cent of cases witnessed the administration of antibiotics without a prescription. This alarming trend underscores the urgent need for increased public awareness, stricter regulations, and a comprehensive approach to address the misuse of antibiotics.

In a study examining the response to antimicrobial resistance in the South-East Asia region, published in the November 2023 issue of The Lancet, it was found that the total consumption of antibacterial drugs in Nepal was 60 defined daily doses (DDD) per 1000 inhabitants per day in 2018, a stark contrast to the mere 14 DDD in central Europe. Additionally, the study revealed that a concerning 70-80 percentage of the most common pathogens in Nepal exhibit resistance to almost all antibiotics. The research further highlighted that 60 percentage of infection-related deaths in Nepal were attributed to antibiotics resistance, and an additional 20 percentage of deaths were directly associated with antibiotic-resistant strains.

Risk of disease spread

Antimicrobial resistance occurs when pathogenic microbes undergo changes over time, rendering them unresponsive to medications. This phenomenon makes infections more challenging to treat, escalating the risk of disease spread, severe illness, and mortality. Consequently, medicines lose their effectiveness, allowing infections to persist and increasing the likelihood of transmission to others. In Nepal, despite antibiotics being prescription drugs, they are easily accessible over the counter. A significant number of individuals acquire them without disclosing their specific health issues to pharmacists.

Additionally, pharmacists frequently overlook inquiring about the nature of the ailment and often fail to emphasise the crucial importance of completing the prescribed medication course. This laxity is recognised as a primary factor contributing to the increasing rates of antimicrobial resistance in Nepal. Another contributing factor lies in the widespread practice of doctors prescribing antibiotics based solely on preliminary clinical diagnosis. It is known that antibiotics prove ineffective against viral infections, underscoring the imperative for a more discerning approach to prescription practices in order to curb the surge of antimicrobial resistance.

On a personal note, during my visit to Nepal last winter, I had to take my two children to a nearby hospital three times due to various health complications. On each occasion, the doctor nonchalantly prescribed antibiotics, whether it was for a trivial thumb wound, a skin allergy, or a suspected case of food poisoning. Engaging in conversation with the pharmacist, I discovered that almost 50 percentage of the daily drug sales in the pharmacy located outside that hospital contributed to the antibiotics prescribed by the doctors. Moreover, a prevalent trend also existed among patients, where there was a significant demand for antibiotics without a doctor's prescription.

> Various reports have shown that educational interventions have proven successful in diminishing the prevalence of antibiotic use without a prescription.

A multi-pronged approach is required to address antibiotic misuse, beginning with robust public awareness campaigns. Educating communities about the importance of completing antibiotic courses, the dangers of self-prescribing, and the implications of antibiotic resistance is crucial. Collaborative efforts between healthcare providers, educational institutions, and community organizations can play a pivotal role in disseminating this information. Various reports have shown that educational interventions have proven successful in diminishing the prevalence of antibiotic use without a prescription.

Strengthening regulatory measures is also essential to curb antibiotic misuse. Stricter controls on over-the-counter sales, enhanced monitoring of prescription practices, and penalties for unauthoriSed antibiotic distribution can act as deterrents. Additionally, creating a centralied database to track antibiotic consumption and resistance patterns can aid policymakers in implementing evidence-based interventions.

In addition, training healthcare providers on prudent antibiotic prescribing practices is pivotal. Implementing guidelines for diagnosis and treatment, encouraging the use of narrow-spectrum antibiotics, and promoting regular antimicrobial stewardship programs can help align medical practices with global efforts to combat antibiotic resistance.

Antibiotics in livestock

The use of antibiotics in agriculture and livestock also contributes significantly to the emergence of antibiotic-resistant strains. Agricultural antibiotics play a significant role in fostering the emergence of resistant bacteria in meat and poultry products. A study conducted by Nepal Health Research Council (NHRC) revealed that approximately 70 per cent of farmers employed high doses of antibiotics with increased frequency, aiming for a swifter recovery of sick livestock. Implementing regulations on antibiotic use in these sectors, promoting alternative farming practices, and supporting research on sustainable solutions can help strike a balance between agricultural needs and public health.

To conclude, the concerning rise of antibiotic misuse in Nepal demands urgent attention and concerted efforts from various stakeholders. By raising public awareness, strengthening regulatory frameworks, educating healthcare providers, and addressing the broader issues in agriculture and livestock practices, Nepal can take significant strides towards mitigating the threat of antibiotic resistance and safeguarding the effectiveness of these life-saving drugs for future generations.

(The author is an assistant professor of Neurobiology at Martin-Luther University Halle-Wittenberg, Germanpushpa.joshi@gmail.com)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 8, 1974

Teachers' Seminar Held

Jajarkot, Feb. 7: A three-day long seminar of the teachers of secondary, lower secondary and primary schools of the district was held here recently, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Incentivise Export-oriented Industries



This is in reference to the news story titled *"NCC, ECN agree for export facilitation"* published in this daily on Feb. 7. There is no denying that the export potential of Nepal is huge. From tea, coffee, herbs to hydropower and cement and many more, we can earns billions from the export of these items.

To tap into this potential and to increase exports and reduce trade-deficit, an agreement has been reached between Nepal Chamber of Commerce (NCC) and the Export Council of Nepal (ECN). It goes without saying that our huge trade deficit stands in the way to our prosperity, and without ramping up our export, I don't think we can ever come close to plugging this gap that keeps widening.

The government should work to incentivise export-oriented industries and even give them export subsidy if needed. With the availability of electricity in recent years, this shouldn't be as hard as it used to be. Promoting entrepreneurship culture is also crucial.

Kapil Basyal
Texas, USA

TAILPIECE

A priest and an astronomer find themselves sitting together on a night flight. After introductions and a long gaze out the window, the astronomer asks the priest, "Can't all religions be summed up by stating the Golden Rule?" The priest pauses a bit and asks the astronomer, "Can't all astronomy be summed up by singing 'Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star'?"-

+++++

While proudly showing off his new fraternity house to friends, a college student led the way into the den. "What is the big brass gong and hammer for?" one of his friends asked.

"That's the talking clock", the man replied, with a grin. "Let me show you how it works!" And with that, he gave the gong an ear-shattering pound with the hammer.

Suddenly someone screamed from the other side of the wall, "KNOCK IT OFF, YOU IDIOT! IT'S 2 AM!"

At least 26 killed at election office bombing in Pakistan

AP

Quetta, Pakistan, Feb. 7

A pair of bombings at the election offices of a political party and an independent candidate in southwest Pakistan killed at least 26 people and wounded more than two dozen others, officials said Wednesday, the day before parliamentary elections are to be held.

The first attack hit the election office of Asfandyar Khan in Pashin, a district in Baluchistan province, said Jan Achakzai, the spokesperson for the provincial government. Officials said at least 15 people were killed in the attack and the wounded are being transported to a nearby hospital. Police said some of them were listed in critical condition.

Later Wednesday, another bombing at the elections office of politician Fazlur Rehman's Jamiat Ulema Islam party in Qilla Saifullah town of Baluchistan killed at least 11 people, Acahkzai and local authorities said.

JUI is one of the leading radical Islamist party and is known for backing the Afghan Taliban. JUI's religious schools are spread across the country, especially in the northwest and Baluchistan bordering Afghanistan. Many of Afghanistan's Taliban leaders studied at Islamic seminaries operated by JUI, yet Rehman and his party leaders in recent years have been attacked by the Islamic State group and other militants. Rehman and scores of candidates from his party are contesting the elections from various parts of Pakistan.

No one immediately claimed responsibility for the attacks, which came a day before Pakistan holds parliamentary elections.

Caretaker Prime Minister Anwaarul-Haq-Kakar denounced the bombings in Baluchistan, and conveyed his condolences to the families of those who died. He vowed that "every attempt to sabotage the law and order situation will be thwarted."

Kakar said the government is committed to holding elections in a peaceful environment.

Caretaker Interior Minister Gohar Ejaz also denounced the bombings, saying no one would be allowed to sabotage the election process.

The bombings came despite the deployment of tens of thousands of police and paramilitary forces across Pakistan to ensure peace following a recent surge in militant attacks in the country, especially in Baluchistan.

The outlawed Baluchistan Liberation Army has been behind multiple attacks on security forces, including a Jan. 30 attack on security facilities that killed six people.

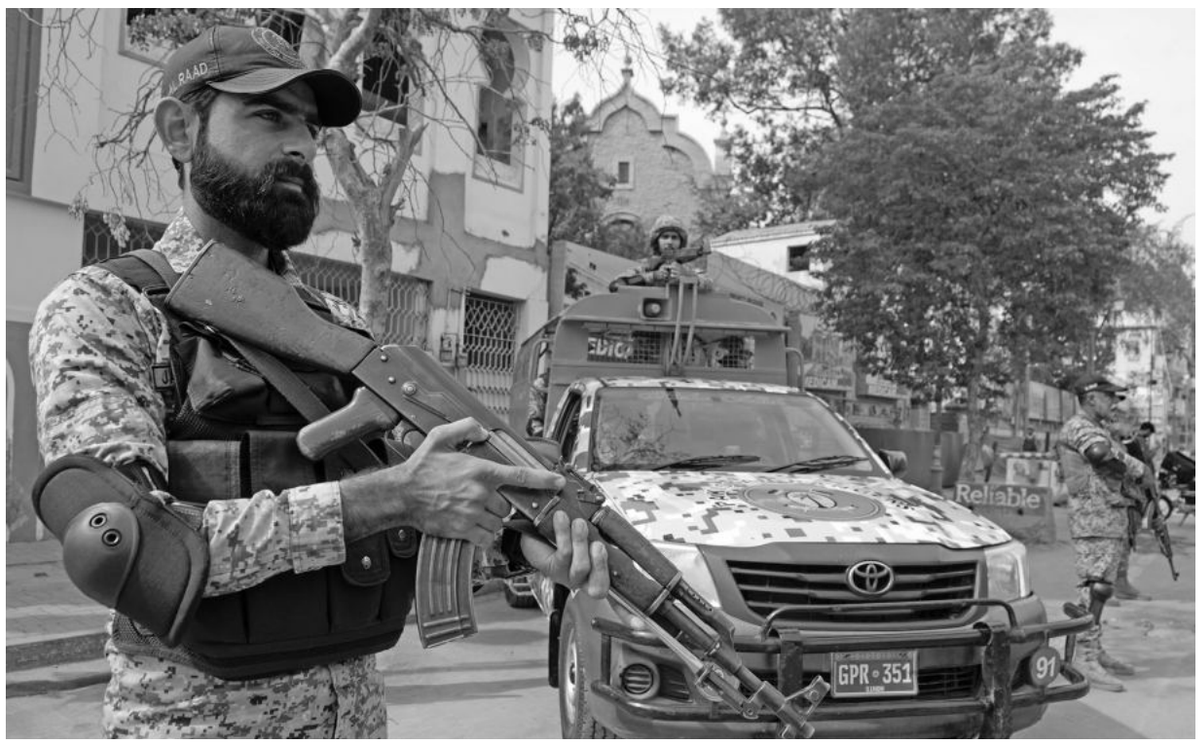


PHOTO: AP

Paramilitary soldiers stand guard on the side of a road for security, ahead of Feb. 8 general elections, in Karachi, Pakistan, Wednesday, Feb. 7, 2024.

Russia attacks targets across Ukraine

AP

Kyiv, Ukraine, Feb. 7

Russia fired cruise and ballistic missiles and Shahed-type drones at six regions across Ukraine on Wednesday morning, authorities reported, killing at least four civilians and injuring 25 others, including a pregnant woman.

The attacks targeted at least three major cities, including the capital Kyiv, where the European Union's top diplomat, Josep Borrell, was discussing military aid and financial support for Ukraine. He said he started his day in an air raid shelter, calling it part of Ukraine's "daily reality" after almost two years of war.

The West's help is desperately needed by Ukraine, which is struggling with ammunition and personnel shortages. Some long-term foreign funding is also in doubt as the latest effort to clinch a deal on Ukraine aid in the U.S. Senate collapsed Tuesday.

Though the roughly 1,500-kilometer (900-mile) front line has barely budged in recent months, the Kremlin's forces have the upper hand in stocks of missiles and artillery ammunition used for long-range strikes. Russia has repeatedly used missiles to blast civilian targets during the conflict.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said last month that air defense and electronic warfare systems that can stop drones are Kyiv's top priorities.

Ukraine's Armed Forces said they intercepted 44 drones and missiles out of 64 that were launched in the morning attack.

The barrage killed four people in Kyiv, the State Emergency Service said.

The attack also killed a man in Mykolaiv, a city in southern Ukraine, where some 20 residential buildings and public infrastructure were damaged, regional Gov. Vitalii Kim said.

Nineteen people were injured in Kyiv, according to the Interior Ministry, including a pregnant woman.

Apartment buildings caught fire in multiple Kyiv districts, Mayor Vitalii Klitschko said. Two power lines damaged during the attack left some residents on Kyiv's east bank without power.

In Kharkiv, in northeastern Ukraine, a 52-year-old woman was slightly injured in an S-300 missile attack, regional Gov. Oleh Syniehubov said.

Missiles also hit as far away as the Lviv region of western Ukraine, where a fire broke out, officials said.

> The West's help is desperately needed by Ukraine, which is struggling with ammunition and personnel shortages. Some long-term foreign funding is also in doubt as the latest effort to clinch a deal on Ukraine aid in the U.S. Senate collapsed Tuesday.

Syria says Israeli airstrikes killed civilians

AP

Damascus, Syria, Feb. 7

Israeli airstrikes over the central city of Homs and nearby areas killed and wounded civilians, the Syrian military said Wednesday.

There was no immediate comment from Israel.

Syrian state news agency SANA quoted an unidentified military official as saying the strikes late Tuesday damaged both private and public property, without giving additional details.

The Israeli jets reportedly struck the Syrian city and the countryside from over the Mediterranean Sea near the Lebanese coastal city of Tripoli.

The strikes come as tensions across the Middle East flare with the Israeli-Hamas war and a drone attack on Jan. 28 that killed three U.S. troops and injured dozens more in northeastern Jordan, near the Syrian border.

The pro-government Sham FM radio station said the areas struck included the affluent al-Malaab neighborhood and Hamra Street. It said Israel hit farmland in al-Waer, causing fires but no casualties there.

It said at least nine explosions were heard in Homs and its outskirts, where Hezbollah is reportedly present.

Britain-based pro-opposition war monitor the Syrian Observatory for Humanitarian Rights said at least six civilians were killed, among them a woman and a child, as well as two militants from the Lebanese Hezbollah group.

The casualties were all in a building on Hamra Street that was apparently targeted in one of the strikes, it said. Search efforts were ongoing, the Observatory added.

It said at least nine explosions were heard in Homs and its outskirts, where Hezbollah is reportedly present.

Israel has carried out hundreds of strikes on targets inside government-controlled parts of war-torn Syria in recent years.

Israel rarely acknowledges its actions in Syria, but it has said it targets bases of Iran-allied militant groups such as Hezbollah, which has sent thousands of fighters to support Syrian President Bashar Assad's forces. It has also targeted members of Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard in Syria, including a high-ranking general last December.

> Israel has carried out hundreds of strikes on targets inside government-controlled parts of war-torn Syria in recent years.

Blinken in Israel to brief leaders on cease-fire

AP

Tel Aviv, Israel, Feb. 7

U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken was set to meet Israeli leaders on Wednesday as Hamas put forward a detailed plan for a new cease-fire and hostage release deal, but both sides remain dug in on thus far elusive goals as the war enters its fifth month.

Hamas laid out a three-phase plan to unfold over 4 1/2 months, responding to a proposal drawn up by the United States, Israel, Qatar and Egypt. All hostages would be released in exchange for hundreds of Palestinians imprisoned by Israel, including senior militants, and an end to the war.

The proposal would effectively leave Hamas in power in Gaza and allow it to rebuild its military capabilities, a scenario that Israeli leaders have adamantly rejected. President Joe Biden said Hamas' demands are "a little over the top" but that negotiations will continue.

The deadliest round of fighting in the history of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict has killed over 27,000 Palestinians, levelled, driven the vast majority of Gaza's population from their homes, and pushed a quarter of the population to starvation.

Iran-backed militant groups across the region have conducted attacks, mostly on U.S. and Israeli targets, in solidarity with the Palestinians, drawing reprisals as the risk of a wider conflict grows. Israel remains deeply shaken by Hamas' Oct 7 attack, in which militants burst through the country's vaunted defenses and rampaged across southern Israel, killing some 1,200 people, mostly civilians, and abducting some 250, around half of whom remain in captivity in Gaza.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu says the war will continue until "total victory" over Hamas and the return of all the remaining hostages.

Blinken, who is on his fifth visit to the region since the war broke out, is trying to advance the cease-fire talks while pushing for a larger postwar settlement in which Saudi Arabia would normalize relations with Israel in return for a "clear, credible, time-bound path to the establishment of a Palestinian state."



PHOTO: AP

US Secretary of State Antony Blinken, left, shakes hands with Qatar's Prime Minister and Foreign Affairs Minister Mohammed Bin Abdulrahman Al Thani, at Diwan Annex, in Doha, Qatar, Tuesday, Feb. 6, 2024.

PRISM

Wallet lost 40 years ago returned to Ontario family

A wallet lost for 40 years was returned to an Ontario family after being found in an air duct at a storage facility. Andrew Medley of Detroit said he was working on a storage unit at Eaton Centre in Toronto when he found a wallet in an air duct.

"I took the wallet out and I was with a colleague at the time, and we opened it up. We thought maybe it was a couple years old and we were just shocked at how well preserved everything was in there," Medley told CBC News.

Medley was able to find the wallet's owner on Facebook and sent messages to the woman and her daughter, Vanessa Austin.

Firefighters rescue dog from frozen Illinois pond

Firefighters in Illinois donned protective gear and broke through the ice of a frozen pond to rescue a stranded dog. Long Grove Fire Protection District firefighters said they responded to an icy pond off Route 53 to rescue a 120-pound great pyrenees named Belle who fell through the ice.

Roseanne Stavro, Belle's owner, said she found her feet getting stuck in the sand at the bottom of the pond when she attempted to mount her own rescue, so she contacted firefighters.

Stavros said Belle had been in the water for about 30 minutes when rescue crews arrived

(UPI)

Rome partially restores Trajan's Basilica

AFP

Rome, Feb. 7

Rome's most majestic forum has recovered some of its former glory with a partial reconstruction of the imposing columns of Trajan's basilica – using funds from a now-sanctioned Russian oligarch.

The restoration of a portion of the Basilica Ulpia, which soared above the ancient Italian city for over a millennia, helps bring to life the grandeur and magnificence of the original marble monument.

While most work on Rome's ubiquitous ruins points downwards, the rebuilding of the basilica's two-storey Corinthian colonnade has brought the focus up – over 23 metres to be exact.

"If visitors can't sense the height of the monuments, they won't understand the meaning of the architecture," Claudio Parisi Presicce, Rome's top official for cultural heritage, told AFP on a tour of the site.



The Basilica Ulpia was the centrepiece of Trajan's Forum, the largest and last of the imperial forums, named after Marcus Ulpius Traianus, emperor from 98 to 117 AD.

Inaugurated in the second century, it mostly collapsed during the Middle Ages, but was unearthed by excavations in the early 19th century and 1930s.

The current project, which began in 2021, identified three green marble columns that had been left for nearly 100 years "propped up in a corner with no connection with the floor plan," Parisi Presicce said.

Engineers returned them to their proper place atop four granite pillars that mark the outer perimeter of the basilica's first nave.

Between the two stories of columns, archaeologists and technicians have recreated the entablature with its decorative frieze depicting winged victories sacrificing bulls.

The project was funded with a 1.5-million-euro donation made in 2015 by Uzbekistan-born oligarch Alisher Usmanov.

He was later sanctioned by the European Union and US following Russia's invasion of Ukraine, accused by the US Treasury of being close to Russian President Vladimir Putin.

Estimated by Forbes last year to possess a $14.4 billion fortune from the metals and mining industries, Usmanov is an Italophile who had previously given money for Rome restoration projects.

He was named the "most generous charity donor" by the Sunday Times' Rich List in 2021, having donated 4.2 billion to charity over 20 years.

Parisi Presicce brushed aside questions about the donation, reiterating that it was made before Usmanov was sanctioned and noting that Rome's ancient heritage was "universal".

Trajan's extensive military campaigns, including his near-annihilation of the Dacians in today's Romania, extended Rome's boundaries to their farthest limits.

His two bloody Dacian wars are depicted in a spiralling bas relief on Trajan's Column, located just north of the basilica, a monument built to glorify the emperor's victories and his spoils of war.

With the basilica, Trajan "built a monument using the most precious materials that could be used for that moment", said Parisi Presicce, such as coloured marbles mined in far-away Egypt, Asia and Africa.

The basilica, home to civil and criminal courts and other state business, was made up of five central aisles separated by rows of columns.

Built by celebrated architect Apollodorus of Damascus, it was covered by a bronze roof, while statues of conquered Dacians and decorative panels of military banners decorated the facade.

TODAY IN HISTORY

421 – Constantius III becomes co-emperor of the Western Roman Empire.
1250 – Seventh Crusade: Crusaders engage Ayyubid forces in the Battle of Al Mansurah
1817 – An army led by Grand Marshal Las Heras crosses the Andes to join San Martín in the liberation of Chile from Spain.
1837 – Richard Johnson becomes the first and only Vice President of the United States chosen by the Senate.
1879 – Sandford Fleming first proposes the adoption of Universal Standard Time at a meeting of the Royal Canadian Institute.
1879 – England's cricket team, led by Lord Harris, is attacked in a riot during a match in Sydney.[24]
1885 – The first Japanese immigrants arrive in Hawaii.
1887 – The Dawes Act is enacted, authorizing the U.S. President to divide Native American tribal land into individual allotments.

WARD CHAIR OPPOSES PARKING BAN IN NEW ROAD

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 7

Chini Kaji Maharjan, the ward chairman of Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC)-22, said that there was no need for conducting ward-level elections if the metropolis would make unilateral decisions without coordinating and consulting with the wards.

Speaking at a press meeting organised in the New Road on Wednesday, Maharjan said that parking prohibition in the New Road area had adversely affected businessmen.

He said, "The metropolis decided to prohibit parking in New Road, a business hub, from January 23 without consulting with the ward. Instead of approaching feasible alternatives, the sudden decision to impose a ban on parking has created problems for businessmen in the area."

Stating that the metropolis had previously awarded parking contracts to contractors resulting in unmanaged traffic, Ward chair Maharjan said that parking contracts should be assigned to the ward and local bodies. He said, "We have prepared parking plans in the area after studying space availability and the needs of traders. This would be a win-win situation for consumers, traders and the metropolis as well."

Sagar Shakya, a chairperson of Khichapokhari New Road Business Association, said that many traders had invested in the New Road area due to the availability of various facilities like water, electricity and banking including parking. Stating that the flow of customers was declining due to a lack of parking space, he said that if the situation persisted, the area would be soon deserted.

He said that instead of adding facilities to their denizens, the metropolis had cut off available facilities. The metropolis needs to come up with a report on feasible studies to save the businesses adversely affected by the 2015 earthquake, COVID-19 and now the parking problem.



PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET/TRN

A vendor selling dragon fruits at Narayanghat in Chitwan district.

IFRC, WWF join hands to address climate emergency in Nepal

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 7

In response to the escalating impacts of climate change, particularly affecting developing countries like Nepal, the International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent (IFRC) and the World Wildlife Fund (WWF) have joined forces to implement nature-based solutions.

This collaborative effort aims to tackle the climate emergency by leveraging the power of nature, said a press statement issued by WWF on Wednesday.

The strategic partnership, titled "Working with Nature to Protect People," was officially launched on Wednesday in Nepal. This initiative recognises the vital role of nature-based solutions in both mitigating and adapting to climate change while enhancing resilience among communities on the front lines of the crisis.

Nature-based solutions such as forest restoration, water source management, wetland rehabilitation, and riverbank plantations have proven effective in Nepal, providing benefits beyond disaster risk reduction, the statement said.

Dr. Ghana Shyam Gurung, Country Representative of WWF Nepal, emphasized the importance of protecting wildlife and biodiversity at an ecosystem scale to ensure a future where both people and nature thrive together. He called on partners to support the joint efforts of IFRC and WWF Nepal.

The partnership between IFRC and WWF Nepal will utilise their combined expertise and extensive networks to address the ongoing climate crisis and emerging risks. Through local action and collaboration with various stakeholders, including government, development agencies, donors, and private sector, they aim to integrate nature into climate adaptation strategies, the statement read.

Azmat Ulla, Head of Delegation at IFRC, stressed the significance of protecting biodiversity and wildlife in combating climate crises for the well-being of future generations. He urged partners to support the collaborative efforts between IFRC and WWF Nepal.

This joint initiative signifies a crucial step towards addressing the climate emergency in Nepal through the integration of nature-based solutions into adaptation strategies and wider humanitarian and development efforts, they said.

Former Chilean President Sebastián Piñera dies in a helicopter crash

AP
Viña Del Mar, Chile, Feb. 7

Sebastián Piñera, the two-time former president of Chile who faced social upheaval followed by a pandemic in his second term, died Tuesday in a helicopter crash. He was 74.

Chile Interior Minister Carolina Tohá confirmed the death of the former president. No further details were immediately released about the cause of the accident.Serving as president from 2010 to 2014 and again from 2018 to 2022, Piñera led the South American nation during moments of crisis, including the aftermath of an 8.8 magnitude earthquake and tsunami.

He gained a spotlight for his administration's rescue of trapped Chilean miners in 2010, and his governance during the coronavirus pandemic, when Chile was placed among the top five countries for vaccination rates for the illness.

His legacy is marred by violent police repression in October 2019 against protesters who were demonstrating against the country's education, health and pension systems dating to the country's 1973-1990 military dictatorship. A United Nations investigation alleged that police used force "improperly and indiscriminately" injuring protesters, and that government mistreatment of detainees amounted to torture.

The social unrest ultimately led to two attempts to update the constitution that was inherited from the military government, but both have failed.

Piñera's death came as Chile already was recovering from massive deadly wildfires in the county's central region.

Chilean President Gabriel Boric honored Piñera in a speech Tuesday afternoon as a leader "seeking the best for his country," highlighting his management of the pandemic and other emergencies. "He was a democrat from the very first moment," Boric said.

The death also drew an outpouring of condolences from leaders and former leaders across Latin America from both the left and right.

Brazilian President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva wrote on X, formerly Twitter, that it was sad that Piñera had died so "abruptly."

"We worked to strengthen the relationship between our countries and we always had a good dialogue when we were both presidents, and also when we weren't," he said. Argentinian President Javier Milei sent condolences, as did his predecessor, Cristina Fernández de Kirchner.

"As everyone knows, we did not have the same ideas, but we were always united by a relationship of great respect: he was a right-wing man but deeply democratic," Fernández said. "I remember with affection his sense of humor and the warmth of his family, whom I met in Chile."

Piñera was the owner of the fifth-largest fortune in Chile, estimated at some $3 billion. He worked as an academic in several universities for almost 20 years and as a consultant for the Inter-American Development Bank and the World Bank. When he closed his time in office, he had created an estimated 1 million jobs.

As a businessman in the 1970s through the 1990s, he worked in a variety of industries, including real estate. He held shares in major airlines, telecommunication, real estate and electricity companies. He also created one of the largest credit card companies in the country. In 2009, he handed over the management of his businesses to others.

He entered politics representing the center-right, which was the civilian support of the military regime. However, when he served as an independent senator, he voted against the extension of dictator Augusto Pinochet (1973-1990).

Nine Nobel laureates to attend Lumbini...

The province government has allocated Rs. 65 million for the summit.

Preparations are being made in coordination with the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Office of the Chief Minister and Council of Ministers, other ministries, Planning Commission and government and non-government offices in Lumbini Province working in the field of children and peace.

The conference is scheduled to be held from March 10 to 12.

Challenges in the overall development process of children will be discussed for the protection of children around the world who are victims of modern slavery, trafficking, child marriage, child labour and natural disasters.

After the discussion, a manifesto will be issued with the commitment of all to end child abuse.

Lawmakers draw govt attention over slow pace...

detrimental, asserting that such endeavours should be guided by the shared commitment to republicanism and federalism. Sharma commended the efforts to organise the winter session but lamented the previous Parliament's inability to enact crucial laws. Urging clarity and cooperation, he highlighted the need for effective laws in areas like federalism implementation and human capital development to enhance the functioning of provinces and localities.

MP Chitra Bahadur KC, Chairman of Rastriya Janamorcha, questioned the utility of provinces, asserting their relevance only for those advocating federalism. His commentary underscored a longstanding stance against the necessity of provinces, emphasising the efficiency of governance at the union and local levels within Nepal's economic context.

MP Rajendra Prasad Lingden, Chairman of Rastriya Prajatantra Party (RPP), highlighted concerns over the sale and purchase of shares in the telecommunications company Ncell and the implementation of Telecommunication Traffic Monitoring and Fraud Control System (TERAMOX). Lingden drew the government's attention to these matters, indicating a need for scrutiny and clarification. The issues raised suggest a call for transparency and accountability in both the financial dealings of Ncell and the execution of TERAMOX, urging the government to address these concerns for the public's benefit.

MP Ravi Lamichhane, Chairman of Rastriya Swatantra Party (RASWPA), expressed his support for the Speaker's agenda aimed at enhancing the effective operation of the House. Lamichhane conveyed confidence in the successful implementation of the agenda, anticipating that adherence to the schedule would mitigate disruptions experienced in the past. While welcoming the initiative, he voiced discontent regarding the all-party meeting, criticising its focus on partisan interests. Lamichhane suggested holding such meetings in Musahar settlement, emphasizing a need to shift the focus from party leaders' offices to grassroots communities for a more inclusive approach.

Dr. Amresh Kumar Singh, the independent lawmaker, added his critique, focusing on the government's lethargic approach to development work and bringing attention to the plight of builders facing non-payment issues. These issues collectively underscored a sense of urgency for the government to revitalise and expedite ongoing developmental initiatives.

Similarly, a question and answer session with Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' is scheduled to take place in the House of Representatives on February 18. Speaker Dev Raj Ghimire announced this during the House of Representatives meeting, citing paragraph 9 of the Rules of the House of Representatives 2023, which mandates such sessions.

'THAILAND AND MUSLIM SEPARATIST REBELS AGREE ON ROADMAP TO PEACE'

AP
Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia, Feb. 7

Malaysia's facilitator said Wednesday that the Thai government and Muslim separatist rebels in southern Thailand have agreed in principle on a roadmap to try to end a decades-long Muslim insurgency.

The sides held two days of talks in the Malaysian capital, Kuala Lumpur, and will meet again over the next two months to iron out details of the peace plan, said Malaysian facilitator Zulkifli Zainal Abidin.

"It is a major breakthrough after the dialogue was stalled the past year due to the Thai election," he told a news conference.

"The (peace plan), if the technical teams agree, will be signed as soon as possible. ... There is light at the end of the tunnel. Both parties are willing to put pen on paper.

Previously there was no talk of signing any documents."

Lower House approves Anti-Money Laundering Bill

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 7

Today's meeting of the House of Representatives has unanimously approved the Bill on Anti-Money Laundering.

Earlier in the meeting, Minister for Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs, Dhanraj Gurung, had presented the proposal seeking the endorsement of the bill to amend Acts and laws relating to the prevention of money laundering and promotion of business environment.

The endorsement has opened the way for amendment in a host of laws such as Export-Import (Control) Act-2013 BS, Ship Registration Act-2027 BS, Revenue Act-2034 BS, Tourism Act-2035 BS, Building Act-2055 BS, Insolvency Act-2063 BS, Securities Act-2063 BS, Nepal Rastra Bank Act-2058 BS, Human Trafficking and Transportation (Control) Act-2064 BS.

Criminal Assets and Instruments (Seizure, Control and Confiscation) Act-2070 BS, Money Laundering Prevention Act-2064 BS, Organized Crime Prevention Act-2070 BS, Insurance Act-2079 BS, Cooperatives Act-2074 BS, Foreign Investment and Technology Handover Act-2075 BS, Electricity Regulation Commission Act-2074 BS, Mutual Legal Assistance Act-2070 BS will also undergo amendment with today's endorsement.

The National Civil (Code) Act-2074 BS and the National Criminal Procedure (Code) Act-2074 BS have been amended through the Bill.

HoR will meet again on February 18 at 11:00 am. Speaker Devraj Ghimire informed that on that day, the parliamentarians could hold live question and answer session with the Prime Minister.

Interpol issues diffusion notice against Amala Roka

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 7

Interpol has issued a diffusion notice against Amala Roka, a fugitive in the 60.716 kg gold smuggling case.

The Central Investigation Bureau (CIB) had requested the Interpol section at the Nepal Police Headquarters for a diffusion notice against Roka. Interpol subsequently issued the diffusion notice on February 5, according to SP Navaraj Adhikari, who is also the spokesperson for the CIB.

SP Adhikari said that Interpol issued the notice against Roka on the CIB's request.

Roka is the promoter of Hotel Vienna in Thamel, Kathmandu. Her husband Dawa Tshering, a Belgian national, is in prison.

On July 18 last year, a team from the Department of Revenue Investigation (DRI) confiscated a huge quantity of gold hidden inside the brake shoes of scooters during a cargo inspection after it passed undetected through customs at the Tribhuvan International Airport (TIA) in Kathmandu. The total weight of the gold was later found to be 60.716 kilograms. Initially, the weight of the gold was claimed to be 100 kg.

The DRI had initially investigated the accused under the Revenue Leakage (Investigation and Control) Act, while the CIB investigated them under the Customs Act and organised crime after taking charge of the case.

Dawa Tshering was arrested by the DRI, but Roka is still on the run.

The CIB had concluded that the racket that smuggled 60 kilograms of gold had smuggled a total of 362 kilograms of gold. Police said that the same group had also smuggled 9 kg of gold disguised as e-cigarettes (Vapes).

Police had arrested 26 persons in connection with the gold smuggling and filed a case against them. The Kathmandu District Court had remanded 25 of them to custody on October 6 last year.

Dawa Tshering and other accused had filed an application at the Patan High Court against the district court's order. The high court had then released six of the accused on bail and ordered 12 others including Tshering to be kept in a prison.

Arun Chaudhary, two others released on date

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 7

Three persons including businessman Arun Chaudhary who were arrested on charge of converting 10 ropanis of public land belonging to the erstwhile Bansbari Leather and Shoe Factory into private property have been released on general date.

The Central Investigation Bureau (CIB) of Nepal Police released Chaudhary, who was also the promoter of Champion Footwear Limited, then executive chairman of Bansbari Leather and Shoe Factory Ajit Narayan Singh Thapa, and promoter of Chandbagh Residency Private Limited Sanjay Thakur from custody on Wednesday.

The three were arrested in connection with the 'land grab' scam last Wednesday.

The Kathmandu District Court had initially remanded them to custody for four days and then for another two days on Monday.

Stating that it did not appear necessary to keep them in custody for 25 days, a bench of Judge Yagya Prasad Acharya had ordered the three to be released after two days by making them sign necessary documents.

The CIB arrested the three following an investigation for more than three months which it said found their involvement in converting the public land into private property.

It was found that CG Chandbagh Residency was built on 10 ropanis of the public land given to Bansbari Leather and Shoe Factory, the CIB said.

Organising a press conference last Thursday, CIB's Senior Superintendent of Police Dinesh Acharya said that attempts were made to transfer not only 10 ropanis, but the entire 18 ropanis of public land at Bansbari.

The CIB said that Champion Footwear Limited was set up at Bansbari to grab the public land there.

"Although they were arrested and released on Wednesday after the order of the Kathmandu District Court, their connection to and investigation on the file will not be stopped," said SSP Acharya.

"The investigation file against them will be submitted to the District Attorney Office after completing the investigation for further legal action and prosecute the case under fraud and forgery of government documents," SSP Acharya said.

By disclosing his cancer, Charles breaks centuries of royal tradition

AP
London, Feb. 7

In British history, the secrecy of the monarch's health has always reigned supreme. Buckingham Palace's disclosure that King Charles III has been diagnosed with cancer shattered that longstanding tradition.

On the heels of the shock and well-wishing that followed the official statement Monday came the surprise that the palace had announced anything at all. Indeed, the unprecedented missive was sparse on details: Charles, 75, had begun treatment for a cancer it did not name after being diagnosed during a recent corrective procedure for an enlarged prostate. The king is stepping back from public duties but carrying on state business during his treatment, which he'll receive as an outpatient, the palace said.

"The King has cancer," the Times of London declared in a terse banner headline Tuesday. It was unlike any other in British history. Never complain, never explain, as Charles' late mother, Queen Elizabeth II, was known to say. Charles has withheld details of his illness and treatment, and in that way is carrying on her approach.

Balkrishna Sama's 122nd birth anniversary markeda



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 7

The 122nd birth anniversary of Balkrishna Sama was marked on Wednesday.

By organising a seminar, poetry reading, painting workshop and documentary screening programmes in Kathmandu jointly by the Nepal Academy, Nepal Academy of Fine Arts and Nepal Academy of Music and Drama, playwright Sama was remembered.

Lalkaji Lama, the Vice-Chancellor of Nepal Academy of Fine Arts, delivered the welcome speech at the event, which began with the ceremonial lighting of the lamp by the chancellors of all three academies.

Lama shared insights into Balakrishna Sama and his artistic contributions to various areas like drama, art and literature.

Speaking at the programme, Naradamani Hartmchhali, Chancellor of Nepal Academy of Fine Arts highlighted Sama's role as a guardian of the arts and literature, describing him as a multifaceted personality.

Chancellor Bhupal Rai of Nepal Academy declared that the collaboration between the three academies marked a new standard.

Stating that this is a pioneering and exemplary programme jointly organised by all three academies, Rai said that Sama was not only a great dramatist but also a tall literary figure and painter.

Nisha Sharma, Chancellor of Nepal Music and Drama Academy, lauded Sama's significant contributions across literature, theatre, and painting, expressing anticipation for the artworks inspired by his creations.

Dr. Ashok Thapa presented a paper highlighting the versatility of Sama and expanding his expertise to almost all forms of art.

Additionally, a documentary showcasing Balakrishna Sama's paintings, produced by the Nepal Artist Society and directed by Ramesh Khanal, was screened.

Likewise, poets including Sandhya Pahadi, Radha Karki, Baba Basnet and Bishnu Gyawali recited Sama's poems amid the programme.

Lalkaji Lama of Nepal Academy of Fine Arts made a painting based on the play 'Prahlada' by Sama while academic council members Pradeep Adhikari, Sauraganga Darshandhari, Aruna Hingmang, Ramesh Khanal, along with artists Liladhar KC and Dipendraman Banepali, showcased artworks inspired by Sama's plays such as 'Bhimsenko Antya,' 'Andhabeg,' 'Chiso Chulho,' 'Prempinda' and 'Swasnimanchhe.'

Actor Gina Carano sues Lucasfilm and Disney over her firing from 'The Mandalorian'

AP
Los Angeles, Feb. 7

Actor Gina Carano on Tuesday sued Lucasfilm and its parent The Walt Disney Co. over her 2021 firing from " The Mandalorian," saying she was let go for expressing right-wing views on social media.

The lawsuit Carano filed with help from X, formerly Twitter, in federal court in California alleges her wrongful termination from the " Star Wars " galaxy Disney+ streaming series after two seasons over a post likening the treatment of American conservatives to the treatment of Jews in Nazi Germany.

"A short time ago in a galaxy not so far away, Defendants made it clear that only one orthodoxy in thought, speech, or action was acceptable in their empire, and that those who dared to question or failed to fully comply would not be tolerated," the lawsuit opens. "Carano was terminated from her role as swiftly as her character's peaceful home planet of Alderaan had been destroyed by the Death Star."

The lawsuit alleges she was fired because she "dared voice her own opinions" against an "online bully mob who demanded her compliance with their extreme progressive ideology."

Disney and Lucasfilm have not filed a response to the lawsuit, and representatives did not immediately respond to an email requesting comment. A Lucasfilm statement at the time of her firing said "her social media posts denigrating people based on their cultural and religious identities are abhorrent and unacceptable."

Carano is seeking damages to be determined at trial and a court order that she be recast on the show.

The "Mandalorian," starring Pedro Pascal, has aired for three seasons and is now being turned into a feature film. Several interconnected series also air on Disney+. The lawsuit says Lucasfilm also hurt her future work prospects by making "maliciously false" statements about her.

Carano, a former mixed martial artists who played the recurring character Cara Dune on the bounty hunter tale "The Mandarlorian," deleted the post but it was widely shared online and spurred a trending #FireGinaCarano hashtag.

Carano had previously been criticized for social media posts that mocked mask wearing during the pandemic and made false allegations of voter fraud during the 2020 presidential election. She also mocked the use of gender pronouns in profiles, listing "beep/bop/boop" in her social media bio. She said this was not about mocking trans people but a "Star Wars" reference to R2-D2, and the lawsuit calls it "a playful way to defuse all the harassment she had received." But she alleges the issue led to the company harassing her.

The lawsuit says Carano willingly took part in Zoom meetings with leaders of LGBTQ+ groups at the company's behest with "very positive" results, but that Lucasfilm demanded a public apology in which she admitted "to mocking or insulting an entire group of people, which Carano had never done" and subjected her to other harassment over the issue.

Carano said on social media Tuesday that X had helped fund the lawsuit. X owner Elon Musk shared her post, adding that anyone else who felt they had been wronged by the company should "let us know if you would like to join the lawsuit against Disney."

Annette Bening honored as Harvard's Hasty Pudding Woman of the Year

AP
Cambridge, Feb. 7



Annette Bening, a two-time Golden Globe winner who recently received her fifth Oscar nomination, was feted Tuesday with a raucous parade full of colorful costumes and drag performers as part of festivities honoring her as Harvard University's Hasty Pudding Theatricals 2024 Woman of the Year.

A few hours later, Benning endured a celebrity roast before attending a performance of the Hasty Pudding Theatricals' 175th production, "Heist Heist Baby."

She joined a group of synchronized swimmers on stage doing swim strokes to the song "Pump Up the Jams," a reference to her role in the swimming movie "Nyad." Then, she cut the hair of a volunteer in an effort to give him her signature look. And then she donned a seagull costume and acted out the role of the sea bird, a reference her role in the movie version of Anton Chekhov's "The Seagull," squawking and waving her arms.

"I did it all myself with no one's help," Benning joked, after accepting the traditional pudding pot and trying to start a speech by thanking her kindergarten teacher. Her husband, Warren Beatty, won the man of the year award in 1975.

The Pudding is the oldest theatrical organization in the nation and one of the oldest in the world. Since 1951, it has bestowed this award annually on women "who have made lasting and impressive contributions to the world of entertainment." Other winners have included Meryl Streep, Julia Roberts, Scarlett Johansson and Jennifer Coolidge.

Festivities began with the parade at Harvard. Bening, wearing a brown coat, hat and sunglasses, blew kisses to the crowd, and at one point, was pecked on both cheeks by drag performers. As the parade ended, she launched into a can-can dance with several other people.

"We're absolutely thrilled to honor Annette Bening in this milestone 175th anniversary year for the Hasty Pudding," said Josh Hillers, the organization's president. "Hot off her Oscars nomination for Best Actress, we're excited to present her with the most prestigious award in the entertainment industry."

Taylor Swift launches legal broadside at a college student who tracks private jets via public data

AP
San Francisco, Feb. 7

When it comes to dealing with a Florida college student who uses public data and social media to track the private jets of billionaires, politicians and other celebrities, Taylor Swift apparently can't just shake it off.

In late December, Swift's camp hit Jack Sweeney, a junior studying information technology at the University of Central Florida, with a cease-and-desist letter that blamed his automated tracking of her private jet for tipping off stalkers as to her location. In the letter, attorneys from the law firm Venable accused Sweeney of effectively providing "individuals intent on harming her, or with nefarious or violent intentions, a roadmap to carry out their plans."

Sweeney provided the link to that letter in an email to the Associated Press. In that message, he emphasized that while he has never intended to cause harm, he also believes strongly in the importance of transparency and public information.

"One should reasonably expect that their jet will be tracked, whether or not I'm the one doing it, as it is public information after all," he wrote.



A spokesperson for Swift echoed the legal complaint, saying that "the timing of stalkers" suggests a connection to Sweeney's flight-tracking sites. The spokesperson did not respond to questions seeking elaboration of that charge, such as whether stalkers have been seen waiting for Swift at the airport when her plane arrived or, alternatively, if there is evidence that stalkers have somehow inferred Swift's subsequent location from the arrival time of her flight.

The legal letter likewise accuses Sweeney of "disregarding the personal safety of others"; "willful and repeated harassment of our client"; and "intentional, offensive, and outrageous conduct and consistent violations of our client's privacy."

Such statements are difficult to square with the fact that Sweeney's automated tracking accounts merely repackage public data provided by the Federal Aviation Administration, a government agency. That fact did not dissuade the Venable attorneys, who demanded that Sweeney "immediately stop providing information about our client's location to the public."

The Swift spokesperson did not reply to a question inquiring whether the attorneys had issued the same demand to the FAA.

At one point Sweeney had more than 30 such accounts on Twitter, now known as X after Elon Musk purchased the site for $44 billion in 2022. Musk subsequently had his own dustup with Sweeney, tweeting at one point that his commitment to free speech required him not to ban Sweeney's @elonjet account even though he considered it "a direct personal safety risk."

But it wasn't long before Musk abruptly about-faced and effectively banned the student from X, accusing Sweeney of endangering his personal safety.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: Power struggles in a friend group or organization you belong to could easily escalate out of hand at any moment. As the blazing Sun in your social zone jabs at disruptive Uranus in your values sector.

Taurus: Standing up for your beliefs could seem particularly important today. As you throw yourself into a confrontation with an authority figure, however, you might realize that there's more to the situation.

Gemini: Finding comfortable boundaries with someone else could be a challenge at present. Although you might think reviewing the rules would solve the problem, it's potentially not that simple.

Cancer: Conflict in a close relationship may leave you confused about your next moves. Should you dig deeper into your bond or come up for air? Both approaches are probably necessary to some extent.

Leo: Pushing back against others who won't do a routine task your way could currently be tempting. You probably need more control over something in your life, but this does not have to be it.

Virgo: Your need to express yourself could be strong right now. Even so, picking fights over routine tasks is not the wisest way to get the validation you crave.

Libra: Feeling irritable recently could be a sign that you need more personal space. While the energetic Sun in your expressive 5th house pushes independent Uranus in your intimacy sector.

Scorpio: Petty bickering could currently reveal a valid relationship problem that needs to be addressed. The minor provocation that set off the fight probably isn't the real issue! You may be looking for security.

Sagittarius: Talking a big game might result in you having to take on more work without warning. You may think you can look good in the moment by agreeing to something that you don't really intend to do.

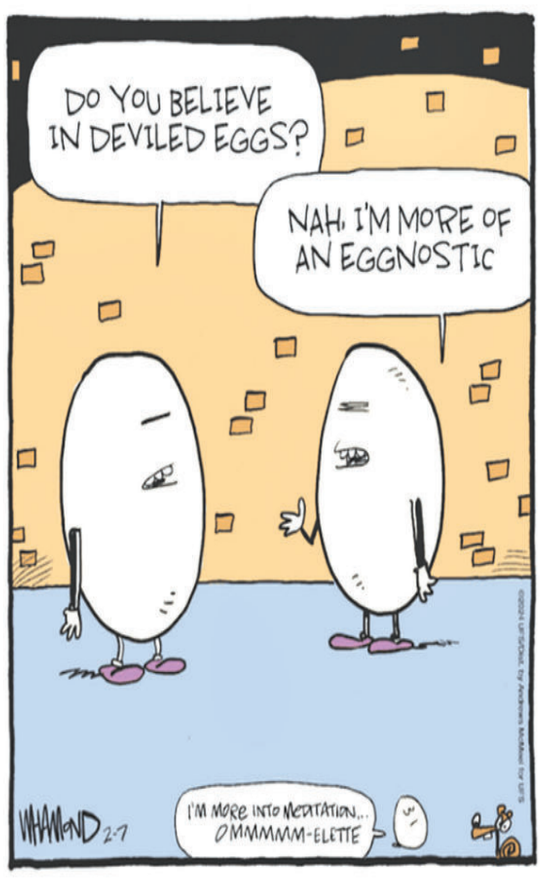
Capricorn: Making more money could feel quite urgent. It may not only be about having a little extra to pay your bills -- your self-worth might also seemingly be at stake! While the vain Sun in your finance zone stirs up volatile Uranus.

Aquarius: Trying to hold back feelings of frustration could make them seem especially overwhelming in the moment. You may fear that asserting yourself runs the risk of threatening something you rely on for security.

Pisces: A fresh tiff on social media could have deep roots. Your reaction might appear out of proportion to the comment that provoked it, but there's probably a long backstory that isn't known to all onlookers.

CARTOON

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Nepal vs Canada: The battle is for good cricket, says coach Desai

BY NAYAK PAUDEL
Kathmandu, Feb. 7



PHOTO: BIKAS/TRN

Coaches and captains of Nepal (Monty Desai and Rohit Paudel) and Canada (Pubudu Dassanayake and Saad Bin Zaffar) during the trophy unveiling ceremony of the Bilateral Series that is going to start on Thursday at TU Cricket Ground, Kirtipur.

"The battle is for good cricket," Nepali cricket team coach Monty Desai said at the pre-match press conference of the Bilateral Series on Wednesday while replying to a question regarding Desai and Pubudu Dassanayake facing against teams they previously coached.

The bilateral series between Nepal and Canada is starting from February 8 in Kathmandu. The three ODI matches will be played at the TU International Cricket Ground with both teams expecting a good number of spectators as usual. With the 1st ODI on Thursday, the 2nd and 3rd ODIs will be played on February 10 and 12 respectively.

Desai worked as the head coach of Canada national cricket team to help the team during the 2019 ICC CWC League 2 matches before joining the West Indies as a batting coach the same year. He has been coaching Nepali cricket team since February 2023.

On the other hand, Pubudu was Nepal's head coach from October 2011 to October 2015. He led the Nepali team to play its maiden ICC T20 World Cup in 2014.

As the two coaches understand their former teams to a great extent, it will add an intriguing dynamic to the three-match series as both teams will try to outsmart the other.

Stating that he was extremely delighted to return to Nepal, Pubudu said, "From being ranked 12th in the world in ODI format in 2009, losing the ODI status and gaining it back, Canada cricket team is thankful for the Cricket Association of Nepal for inviting us to play."

"Nepal will give an opportunity for our team to play in front of a massive crowd because the attendance in Nepal's cricket matches in unparalleled among the associate members. We look forward to giving our best as it will be a good preparation for our ICC CWC League 2 matches in the UAE," Pubudu added.

"It is our first time visiting Nepal. We have been seeing Nepal's matches and how the team is supported by the fans. After regaining the ODI status, there is nothing better than having Nepal as the opponent," said Saad Bin Zafar, Canada cricket team captain.

New players for Nepal

Following their performances in the PM Men's Cup, Anil Sah (best batsman), Surya Tamang (best bowler and best player), Rijan Dhakal and Pawan Sarraf have been called for the bilateral series against Canada.

Rohit Paudel will be captaining the squad which further comprises Aasif Sheikh, Kushal Bhurtel, Dev Khanal, Kushal Malla, Bhim Sarki, Aarif Sheikh, Sompal Kami, Hemant Dhami, Lalit Rajbanshi and Aakash Chand.

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"PM Cup was something I am proud of. It was well organised across three venues. It also allowed the national team to induct promising talents in the squad. The new faces are going well with the happy dressing room," said Desai.

Informing that the squad has been able to train properly only for two days after the PM Cup ended on February 3, Captain Rohit Paudel said, "The national team members played in the 50-over format from different teams in the PM Cup. We were in regular contact. We have not trained together, but we are prepared."

Paudel added, "Karan KC and Gulshan Jha have been given rest for the ICC CWC League 2 matches against Namibia and the Netherlands. We look forward for the new faces to play good cricket."

NZ hammers South Africa by 281 runs

AFP
Mount Maunganui, Feb. 7



Black Caps seamer Kyle Jamieson claimed four wickets on Wednesday to drive New Zealand to a 281-run win over South Africa with a day to spare in the first Test.

Dogged resistance from the tourists ended with their dismissal for 247 at Mount Maunganui as the Black Caps notched their second-biggest Test victory by runs.

New Zealand are a step closer to a maiden series win over South Africa after 17 previous failed attempts, dating back to 1931.

Given their struggles at Bay Oval, the vastly inexperienced Proteas will need a dramatic turnaround to win the second and final Test, starting on Tuesday in Hamilton.

Captain Neil Brand was one of six South African debutants and conceded his team were well off the pace.

"It's very deflating," he said. "We were completely outplayed by a very good New Zealand team.

"Our patience was tested on this wicket. Guys got in, then got themselves out, which is disappointing. Hopefully we can compete more in the second Test."

The tourists were forced to name a depleted tour squad with most first-choice players involved in their domestic Twenty20 competition.

New Zealand took control with 511 in their first innings and never looked like losing when the tourists were dismissed for 162.

The hosts declared at their overnight 179-4 before play began on Wednesday, leaving South Africa to chase an unrealistic target of 529.

Jamieson ensured they never came close, taking 4-58 and producing key double-strikes at the start of the second and third sessions on Wednesday.

The most crucial wicket was that of David Bedingham, who raced to a career-high 87 off 96 balls before he mistimed a pull shot to midwicket soon after tea.

It ended a 105-run stand with Keegan Petersen, who also failed to control a Jamieson short ball on 16.

The day's response had begun disastrously for the tourists, when both openers departed inside the first four overs.

Brand was bowled for three by a late inswinger from his New Zealand counterpart Tim Southee while Edward Moore went for a duck after driving a Matt Henry delivery to cover.

A resolute 63-run stand for the third wicket was broken by Jamieson, who snared Raynard van Tonder at first slip for 31 before Zubayr Hamza's attempted pull shot on 36 flew gently to mid-on.

Spinner Mitchell Santner extracted turn to wrap up the tail and finish with 3-59, matching Jamieson's six scalps for the match.

Rachin Ravindra was named man of the match for his 240 in New Zealand's first innings.

"This rates highly for me, because of the time spent out there and the different people I batted with and the partnerships we managed to put down," Ravindra said after only his fourth Test appearance.

"That makes it a bit more special. It's extremely pleasing we got the job done."

Kane Williamson also shone with the bat, scoring a century in each innings to continue a brilliant run of Test form.

SNIPPETS

Machhindra wins U16 league title

Kathmandu (TRN): Machhindra Football Club emerged victorious in the ANFA U-16 Football League championship on Wednesday. Machhindra came from one goal down to defeat Tribhuvan Army Club 2-1 in the final held at the ANFA Complex in Satdobato, Lalitpur. Machhindra led the table with 38 points from 18 games to win the title. Nepal APF Club finished in second place with 35 points. Sankata secured the third position with 33 points after losing to Nepal Police Club 2-6. Subash Bam from Nepal Police was awarded the Most Valuable Player title, while Pemba Nurbu Bhota from Machhindra won the Best Goalkeeper award. Sabin Lungali Magar from Sankata was declared the top scorer of the youth league.

Junior Taekwondo from today

Kathmandu (TRN): The Jaisidewal Youth Club has announced that the 4th Bagmati Province Level Junior Invitational Mayor Cup Taekwondo Championship 2080 is ready to commence. The two-day championship will begin on February 8 at the Taekwondo Academy hall in Satdobato. A total of 20 teams, comprising 18 municipalities from Bagmati province and two host teams, will compete for 16 gold medals across 8 categories of boys and girls sections respectively. The Kathmandu Metropolitan City is the main sponsor of the event.

According to Rajesh Prajapati, the Chairperson of the organizing Club, the best male and female fighter will receive a cash prize of USD 150. Additionally, the best Poomsae players, best Judge and Best Coach will also be awarded USD 100, respectively. The gold medal winners will also have the opportunity to compete in the international tournament.

2nd Gurkha Trailblazer on March 16

Dharan (TRN): Gurkha Cemeteries Trust Nepal is organising the second edition of Gurkha Trailblazer in Dharan on March 16. Organising a press conference in Dharan on Tuesday, the trust's chairman Mahendra Rai informed that around 500 runners are participating in the 8.5-km-long race starting from Ratna Chowk and ending at the British Gurkha Memorial Park. The top three winners from the men's and women's categories will receive Rs. 15,000, Rs. 10,000 and Rs. 5,000 in cash respectively. The trust, which is a part of a global organisation, is formed in honour of the soldiers who lost their lives in the First and Second World Wars.

Messi wows Tokyo fans in friendly

AFP
Tokyo, Feb. 7



Inter Miami's Lionel Messi pleased Tokyo fans on Wednesday in a friendly match that ended in a 4-3 penalty shootout loss to Vissel Kobe after the game ended goalless.

It came days after his absence on the pitch in a recent Hong Kong friendly had angered fans there.

He started on the bench in Inter Miami's pre-season game against J-League side Kobe, worrying 28,614 spectators at Tokyo's National Stadium, who chanted "Messi, Messi" in sporadic attempts to bring out the star.

They however began to sense their good fortune early in the second half, when the eight-time Ballon d'Or winner and other substitutes began warming up, pleasing hundreds of fans who were seated just behind the Inter Miami bench.

The moment came around 15 minutes into the second half, when the World Cup-winning Argentine replaced David Ruiz, sending the ecstatic crowd into a moment of roaring frenzy that was followed by passionate cheers at his every touch.

In the 79th minute, he dribbled solo into the Kobe box and fired in a close-range shot that was saved by goalkeeper Shota Arai.

Vissel had also showed promise especially early in the match with former Japan international striker Yuya Osako hitting the post 15 minutes into the game.

A minute later, Osako struck the woodwork again.

Kobe won the penalty shootout, with Messi no taking part.

The game drew a sharp comparison from Sunday when Messi and the team's co-owner David Beckham were booed by tens of thousands of fans in Hong Kong after the star did not play in a friendly.

During a press event in Tokyo on Tuesday, Messi said his leg injury was improving but refused to say whether he would play in the Tokyo game.

Tickets for the Japan leg of the US Major League Soccer (MLS) club's globe-trotting pre-season tour cost between 10,000 yen ($68) and 200,000 yen ($1,346) with "special experience" packages priced even higher.

From Asian Cup final to Premier League? Jordan's coach hopes so

AFP
Doha, Feb. 7



Jordan coach Hussein Ammouta hopes their surprise run to the Asian Cup final will spark broader development in the country's football and propel Jordanian players into the Premier League.

Second-half goals from the impressive attacking duo of Yazan al-Naimat and Mousa al-Tamari sent Jordan into the final for the first time with a 2-0 win over South Korea.

South Korea's coach Jurgen Klinsmann and skipper Son Heung-min admitted that Jordan, the lowest-ranked team left in the tournament, fully deserved their semi-final victory on Tuesday.

"The players delivered a heroic performance," the Moroccan Ammouta said after taking Jordan into the final for the first time at their fifth Asian Cup. No matter what happens on Saturday, the widely admired Ammouta says their landmark achievement must be the spark for something longer lasting in Jordanian football.

"We need to invest in infrastructure, in the training and formation of our players to reach higher levels," he said. "We need to pay attention to age categories."

Ammouta says that change is already afoot, citing the example of the impressive Tamari, who together with Naimat terrorised South Korea's shell-shocked defence.

Tamari, who set Naimat up for the opening goal on 53 minutes before slicing through the Korean defence for a second 13 minutes later, left Jordan's domestic league in 2018.

First came a move to Cypriot giants APOEL, before leaving for Belgian football two years later with Oud-Heverlee Leuven.

Last summer, after 10 goals and nine assists for the top-flight Belgian side, Tamari sealed a free transfer to Montpellier in France.

Tamari is the only member of Jordan's Asian Cup squad playing in Europe and Ammouta says for the national side to build on their success in Qatar more need to follow in his footsteps. "What you saw today was the fruit of several years of work," Ammouta said after the South Korea triumph.

"We have Mousa al-Tamari in the French league and hopefully we will have four or five Jordanian players in the French league or the English Premier League. "When you look at Japan or Korea you see players who are playing abroad and they have great value to their national teams.

"This is what we should start planning for -- how will we produce players who will play in the world's biggest leagues?

"This a building block that's part of a bigger plan."

First, Jordan must upset the odds once again in the final in Doha. Ranked 87 in the world by FIFA, they will be the underdogs no matter if they face Qatar or Iran.

Tamari afterwards attempted to deflect from his own man-of-the-match performance against South Korea.

"This victory started with the fans, not us," said Tamari, who was seated at the post-match press conference with Ammouta.

WEATHER

Thursday

Sunrise at 6:47 am, Sunset at 5:49 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Thursday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Possibility of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 18-20 Rain Probability: 0%

Wednesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	23.6	5.4	0.0
Dadeldhura	16.3	3.5	0.0
Dhangadi	21.4	7.2	0.0
Birendranagar	22.7	4.6	0.0
Nepalgunj	21.6	8.8	0.0
Jumla	13.5	-5.4	0.0
Ghorahi	21.8	7.6	0.0
Pokhara	19.5	7.6	0.0
Bhairahawa	21.4	7.5	0.0
Simara	21.2	11.0	0.0
Kathmandu	19.5	3.0	0.0
Okhaldhunga	18.9	4.8	0.0
Taplejung	15.6	3.0	0.0
Dhankuta	18.9	5.8	0.0
Biratnagar	21.0	13.0	0.0
Jomsom	11.1	-2.0	0.0*
Dharan	18.5	8.5	0.0*
Lumle	15.0	3.7	0.0*
Janakpur	23.8	12.5	0.0*
Jiri	17.7	-3.6	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 8, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.46	Rs. 133.06
Euro	1	Rs. 142.65	Rs. 143.29
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 167.32	Rs. 168.07
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 151.78	Rs. 152.47
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 86.48	Rs. 86.87
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.29	Rs. 98.73
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.65	Rs.99.10
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.95	Rs. 8.99
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.41	Rs. 18.49
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.32	Rs. 35.48
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.33	Rs. 36.49
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.72	Rs. 3.74
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.06	Rs. 36.23
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 27.82	Rs. 27.95
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.98	Rs. 10.03
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.64	Rs. 12.70
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.12	Rs. 19.21
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.94	Rs. 17.01
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.23	Rs. 432.18
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.33	Rs. 352.92

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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